Duskara Illustrated

The Atlas and the Plates

1.1.0

Contents

The Living Edge at a Glance iv

The Atlas 1

HD Xanthea and Duskara 2
The Index of the Arc 3
Sheet 1 4
Sheet 2 5
Sheet 3 6
Sheet 4 7
Sheet 5 8
Sheet 6 9
Sheet 7 10
Sheet 8 11
Sheet 9 12
Sheet 10 13
Sheet 11 14
Sheet 12 15
The Bahari 16
The Night Side I 17
The Night Side II 18
The Night Side III 19
The Heights 20
Warmth and Water 21
The Wind and the Storms 22
The Far Edge 23
Liko-Luŋga and Bantay-Hanga 24

The Plates 25

Land and Sky 26
Plate 1: The Belt Across 27
Plate 2: The Sky 28
Plate 3: The Whisper Road 29
Cities and Towns 30
Plate 4: Birni 31
Plate 5: Tafki-Kuu 32

Plate 6: Liko-Luŋga 33
Plate 7: The Town across the Belt 34
Plate 8: A Heartland Town 35
Plate 9: Sickness in the Town 36
Buildings 37
Plate 10: The Common House 38
Plate 11: The Steam House 39
Plate 12: A Growing Tower 40
Plate 13: Bantay-Hanga 41
Plate 14: The Water Judge's Chamber 42
Plate 15: A Storm Haven 43
Plate 16: A Deep Road Gate 44
Daily Life 45
Plate 17: The Ten Bells 46
Plate 18: A Life in Cycles 47
Plate 19: Water in the Hand 48
Plate 20: The Marks of the Kin 49
Under the Night 50
Plate 21: A Deepkin Hearth 51
License 52

About This Book

On Duskara the light does not change and the wind does not stop. People have lived for eight hundred years on a strip of land between a burning day and a frozen night, and the Archivists have drawn it for all of that time: the shore of every lake, the line of every road, the shape of a common house and the order of the bells.

This book collects those drawings. The Atlas shows the land: the star and the planet, the long arc of Daŋa-Hai from end to end, the caves under the night, the heights, the warmth, and the wind. The Plates come closer: the cities and the towns, the buildings that keep people alive, and the ordinary day, from the first bell to the marks a family cuts on its door.

The names are in the Creole, as the Archivists wrote them. Everything else is in English.

How to read a drawing

- **Night and day.** The night side is at the left and the day side at the right, unless a drawing says otherwise. The wind blows from the night to the day, so it blows from left to right.
- **Up-belt.** In the plans and the sheets, up-belt (toward Bundok-Kuu, in the north) is at the top. Positions along the belt are in **alama**, kilometers from Bundok-Kuu; positions across it are the offset, kilometers from the center line, negative to the night side.
- **Scales.** Each drawing gives its scale. Sections often draw heights larger than lengths, and say by how much.
- **Keys.** A numbered circle on a drawing points to the key of the same plate.
- **Figures.** A plain number is a measure of the Accord surveys. “About” marks an estimate. What the Archivists do not know, the drawings say in words.

The inks

The drawings use three inks on a parchment ground.

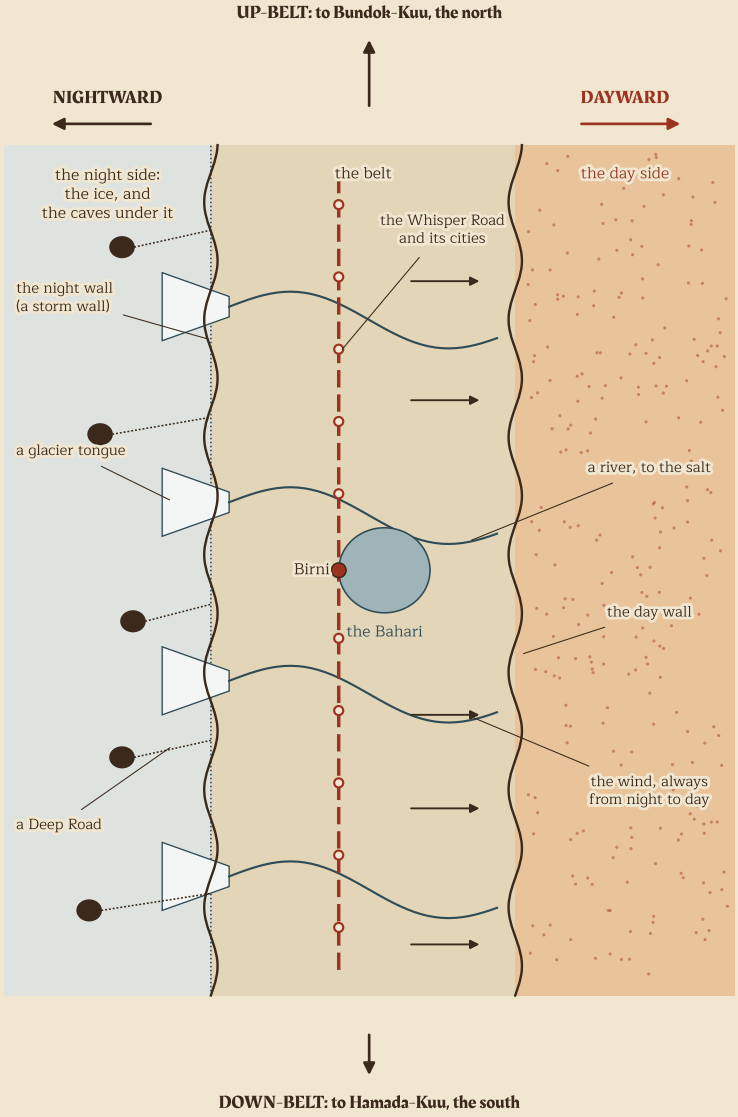
Brown: the ground, stone and earth, and what is built of them; stipple marks a cut.

Red: heat and fire, and what people made on the land: roads, settlements, paths.

Grey-blue: water and ice.

The Living Edge at a Glance

A diagram, not to scale: the directions of the drawings, and what keeps people alive



One face to the star

Duskara turns once in each orbit, so one half always faces the red star and the other never sees it. The light in the belt does not change: no day and no night, only the ten bells and the Cycles, one orbit of about 35 days.

Why the belt can live

The day side is about 80 to 150 degrees, the night side -60 to -100. Between them a ring of twilight runs round the planet through both poles. The world is dry: its water lies frozen on the night side, and the glaciers melt where the ice meets the belt.

The wind

Cold air falls off the ice and runs along the ground toward the day; warm air goes back above it. The wind never stops, and it always blows from the night to the day. Where the currents clash, at the edges of the belt, stand the storm walls.

Water

The rivers come off the ice, run dayward across the belt and end in the salt. Water is not rare, but it is brief: a town catches it, uses it, cleans it and gives it back. Waste is the worst of faults.

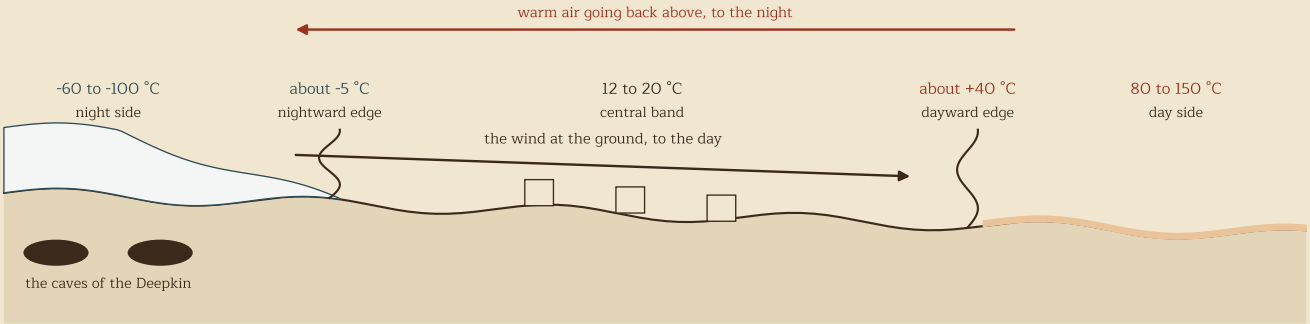
Two peoples

Some 32 million Belters live along one arc of the ring, Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge, about 6,000 km long. About 8 million Deepkin live in caves under the ice beside it, warmed by the vents of the rock.

Roads

The Whisper Road runs along the arc: two days from one city to the next, or ten to twelve by caravan. The Deep Roads, dug by the Deepkin, go across, from the caves to the belt and from cave to cave.

Across the belt, from the ice to the scorched rock



How the numbers are given. A plain number is a measure of the Accord surveys. "About" marks an estimate. What the Archivists do not know, the drawings say in words.

A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

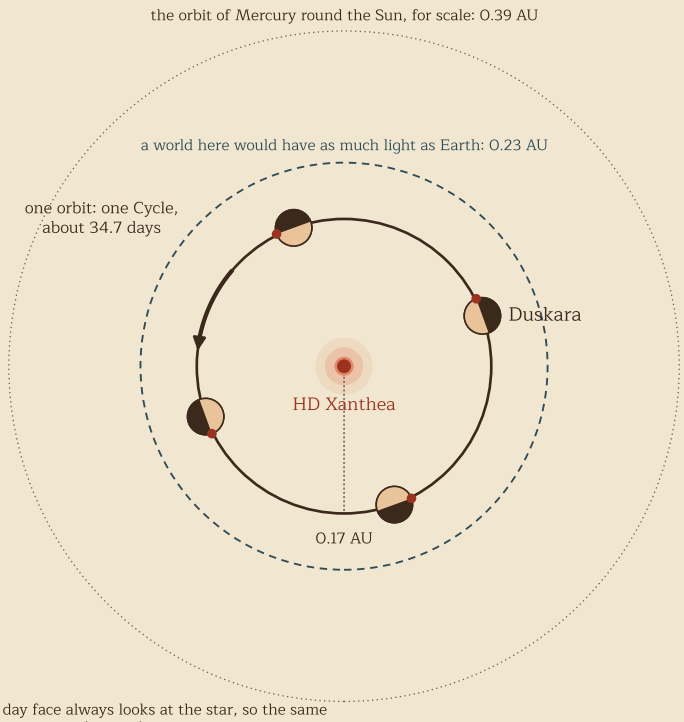
The Atlas

The Atlas begins far out, with the red star the settlers call the Lion and the planet that always shows it the same face. Then it comes down to the ground. An index sheet gives the whole of Daŋa-Hai, six thousand kilometers of it, and twelve sheets follow it in order from the cold north end, five hundred kilometers each. After them come the Bahari, the great lake at the heart of the arc; three sheets of the night side, where the Deepkin live in the warm rock under the ice; the heights, the warmth and the water, the wind and the storm walls; the Far Edge, the whole belt as one ring round the planet; and a closer look at one stretch of the land.

HD Xanthea and Duskara

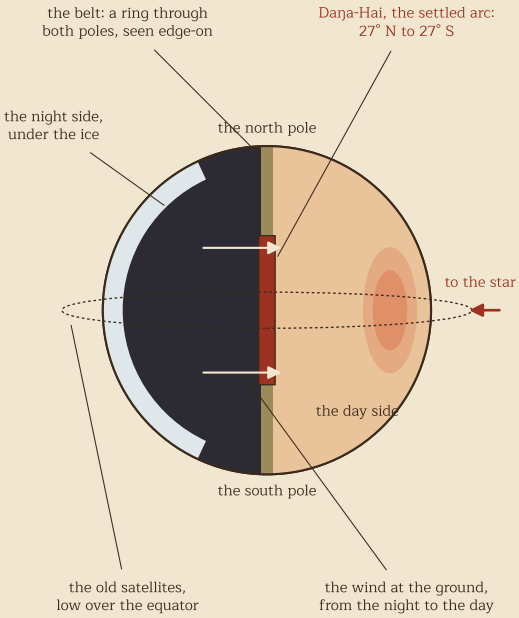
The star, the orbit, and where the belt lies on the planet

The orbit, from above · to scale, except the planet and the star

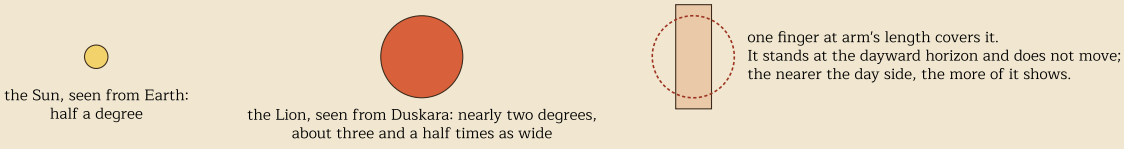


The day face always looks at the star, so the same face of the belt (red dot) is always at its edge.

The planet, with the star to the right



The Lion in the sky



The star

Name	HD Xanthea; in the Creole sora, or simba-taiyo, the Lion
Kind	A red dwarf, M0 to M1, at the warm end of its class
Mass	About 0.55 of the Sun of Earth
Light	About 0.05 to 0.06 of the Sun
Age	About 4 to 5 billion years
Activity	Quiet for a red dwarf; it flares, and the flares light the auroras
The star's breath	Its activity rises and falls over about seven years (74 Cycles)

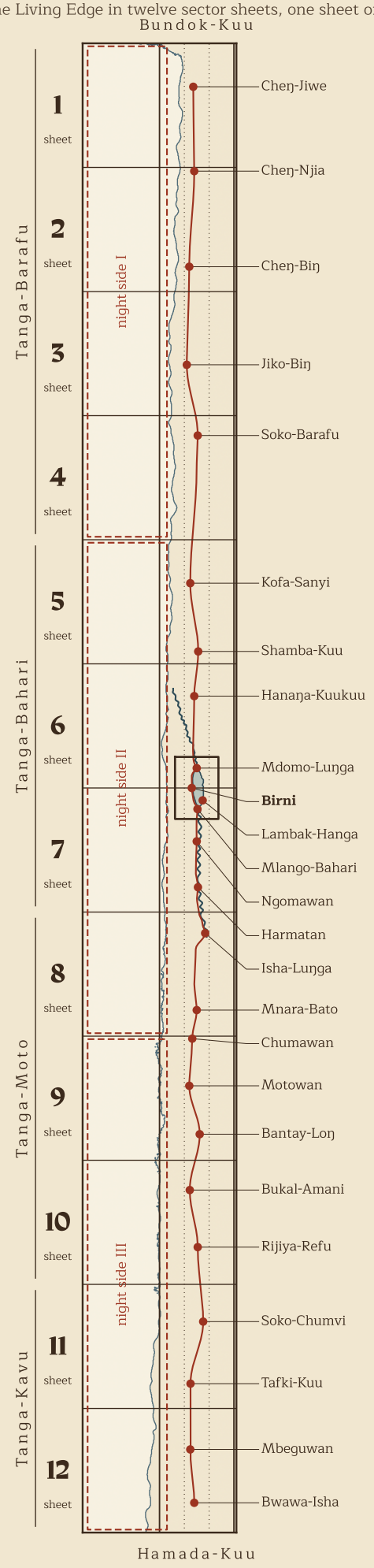
The planet

Orbit	About 0.17 AU from the star
A Cycle	One orbit: about 34.7 days, the unit of dates
Light	About twice what Earth has from the Sun
Rotation	Locked: one face always to the star
Tilt	Less than one degree; no seasons
Size	1.00 to 1.05 Earth across; 1.00 to 1.10 its mass; about 1 g
Air	Nitrogen 76 to 78%, oxygen 20 to 22%; about 1 bar
Warmth	Day side 80 to 150 °C; night side -60 to -100 °C; the belt -5 to +40 °C
The belt	200 to 300 km wide, 40,000 km round; the settled arc, Daŋa-Hai, is 6,000 km of it

The planet and the star are drawn larger than their size; the orbits are to scale. AU: the distance from Earth to the Sun, the old measure of the ship. Why a world so close to its star can live: it is dry, its water is frozen on the night side, and its wind carries the heat of the day to the belt. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The Atlas of Daŋa-Hai

The Living Edge in twelve sector sheets, one sheet of the Bahari, three night-side sheets and the supporting sheets



The signs

- Mountain rock and snow
- Icy plateau
- Icy steppe, with frostblooms
- Misty wetland
- Fertile valley: fields and groves
- Grassland
- Desert scrubland
- Badlands
- Dunes
- Salt flat
- Stone plain
- Scorched rock of the day side
- Ice
- River, stream, lake shore
- Contour; each fifth is heavy
- Edge of the belt
- Limit of the Central band
- Whisper Road
- Track
- Deep Road
- Tunnel to a gate
- Major city
- Other place
- Deepkin community
- Entrance to the Deep Roads

How to read a sheet

Up-belt is at the top. The night side is at the left, the day side at the right, and the wind blows from left to right.

The side scales are alama: kilometers from Bundok-Kuu along the line of the main Whisper Road. The top and bottom scales are the offset: kilometers from the center line of the belt, negative to the night side.

A sector is 500 km of alama. A block is 25 km, which is one day by caravan.

Brown ink is the ground. Red ink is what people made, and the rock of the day side. Grey-blue is water and ice.

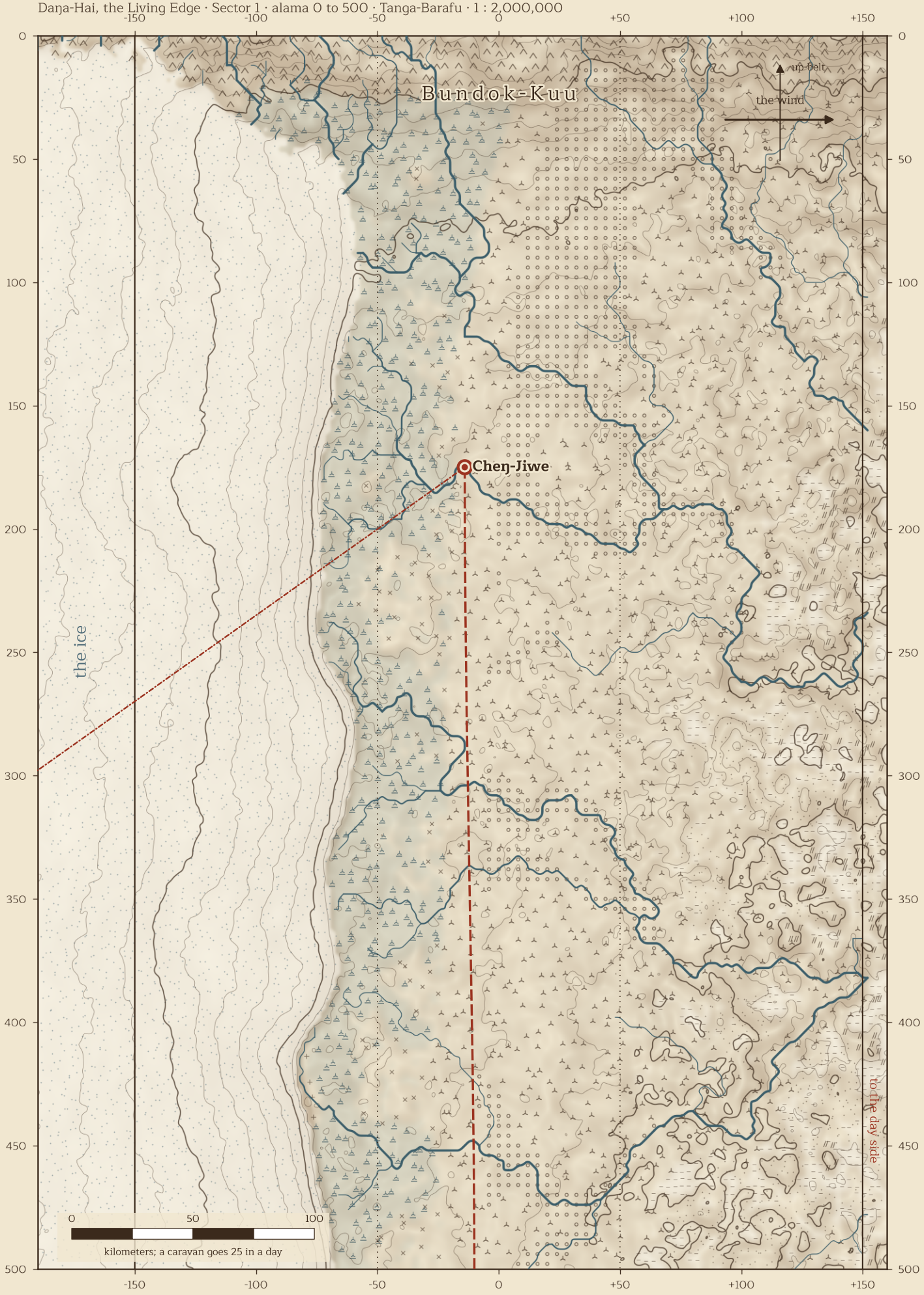
The supporting sheets

The heights
Warmth and water
The wind and the storms
The Far Edge: the whole belt as a ring
Liko-Luŋga and Bantay-Hanga

Sheets 1 to 12 at 1 : 2,000,000. The Bahari at 1 : 1,000,000 (black box). Night side I to III at 1 : 4,000,000 (red boxes).
The heights, the warmth and the wind at 1 : 8,000,000, in three strips. Local sheets at 1 : 250,000.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 1

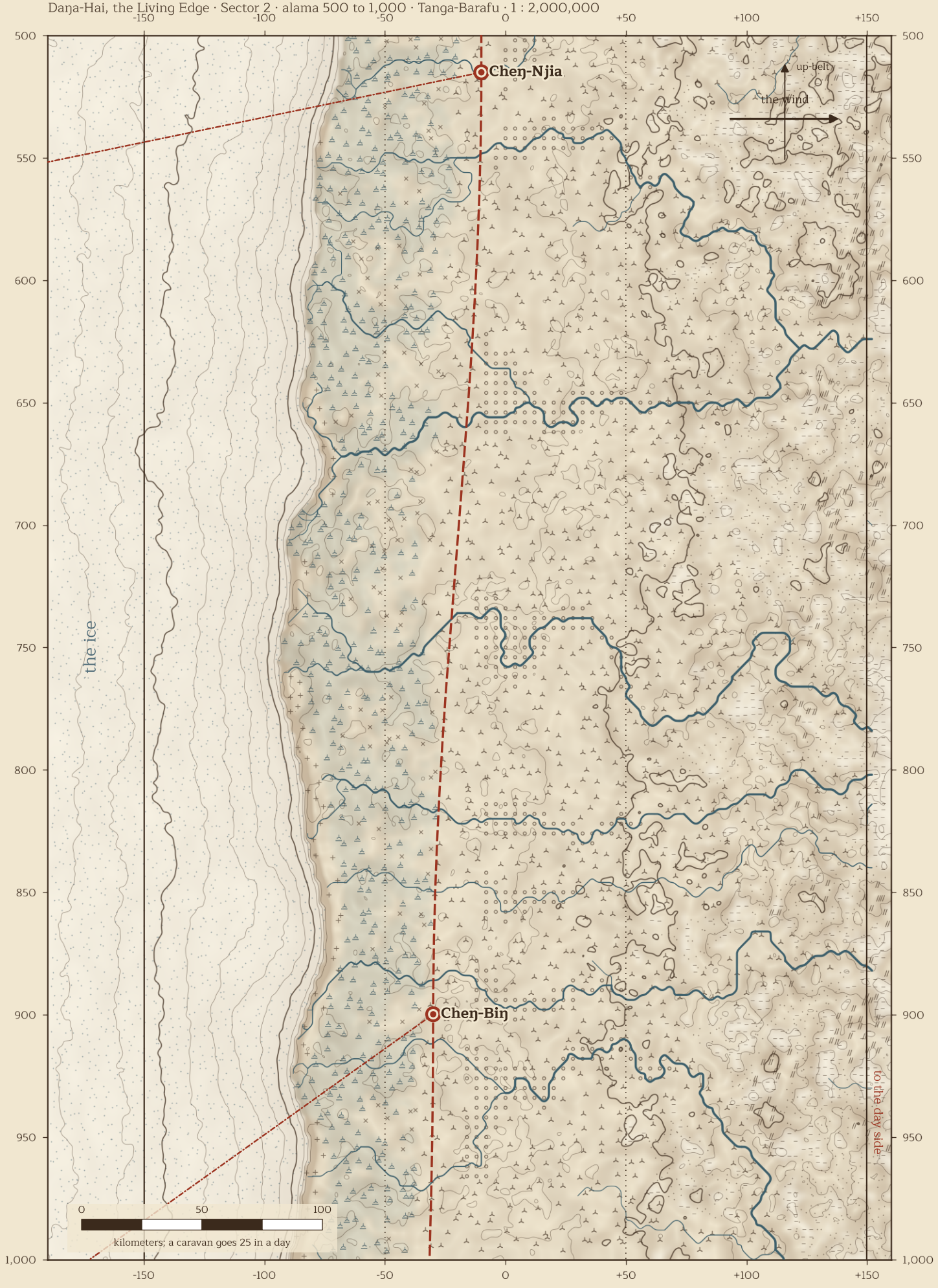
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 1 · alama 0 to 500 · Tanga-Barafu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: Bundok-Kuu closes the arc; nobody has a survey beyond it. Down-belt: sheet 2. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 2

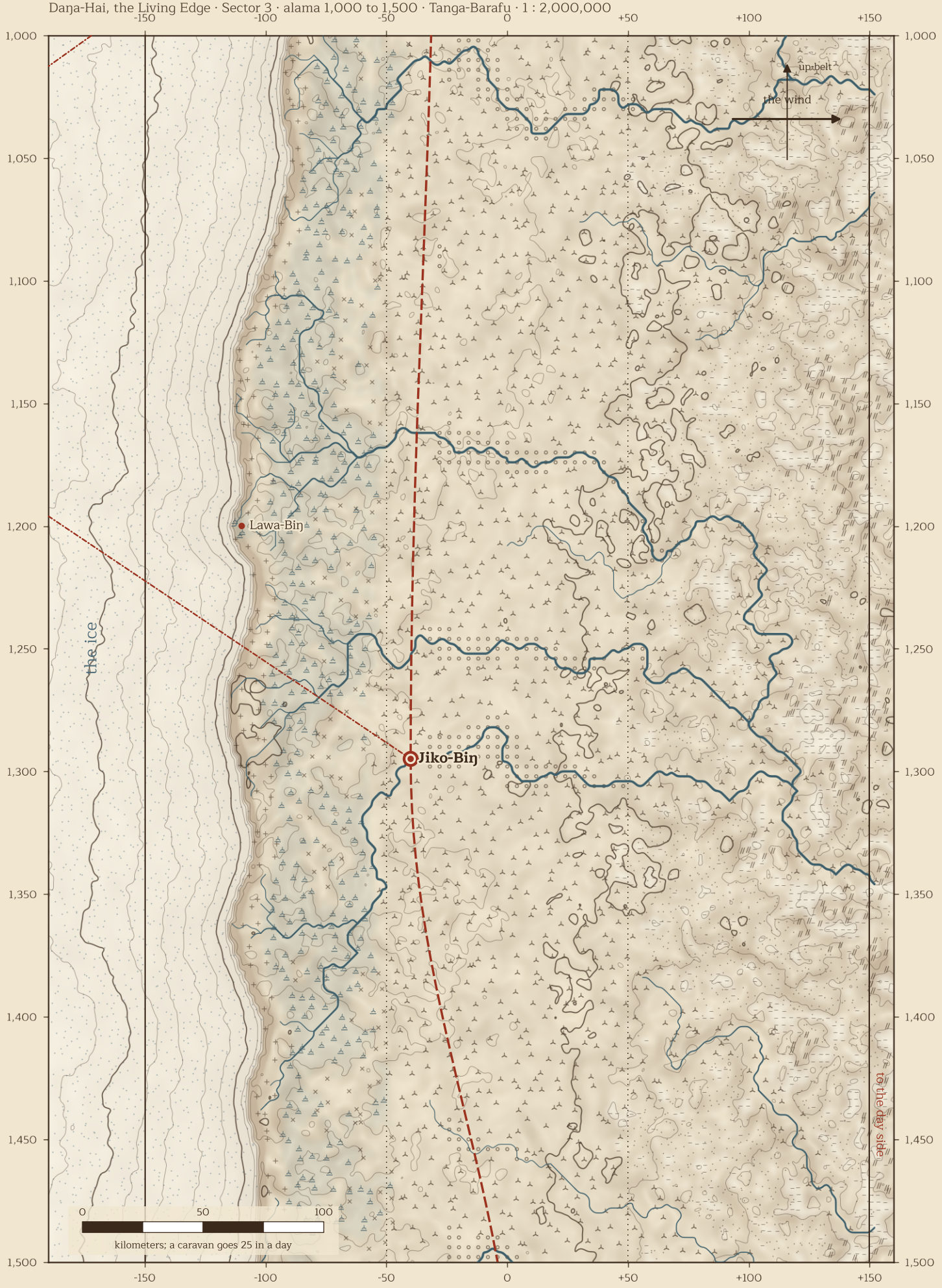
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 2 · alama 500 to 1,000 · Tanga-Barafu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 1. Down-belt: sheet 3. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 3

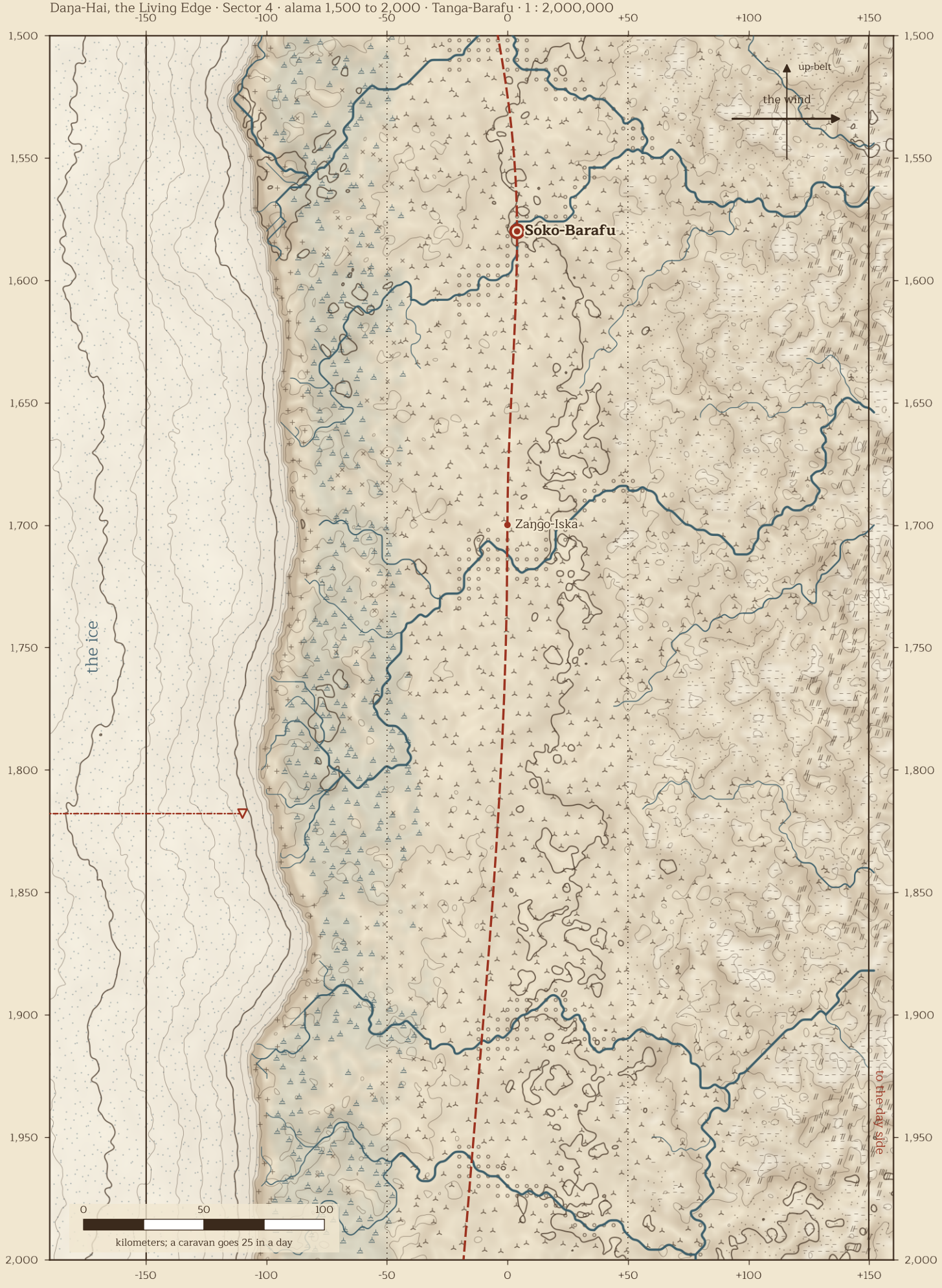
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 3 · alama 1,000 to 1,500 · Tanga-Barafu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 2. Down-belt: sheet 4. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 4

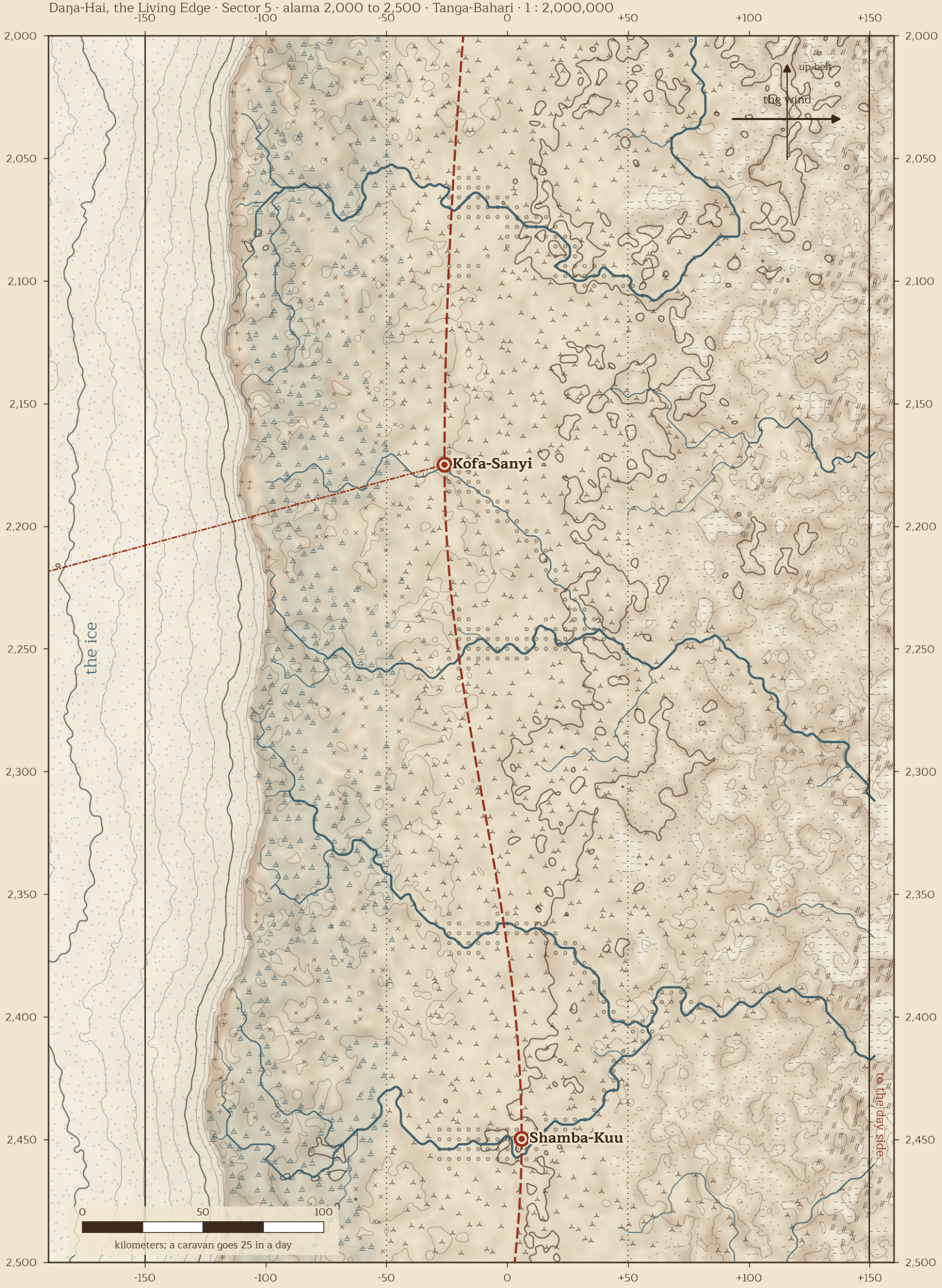
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 4 · alama 1,500 to 2,000 · Tanga-Barafu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 3. Down-belt: sheet 5. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 5

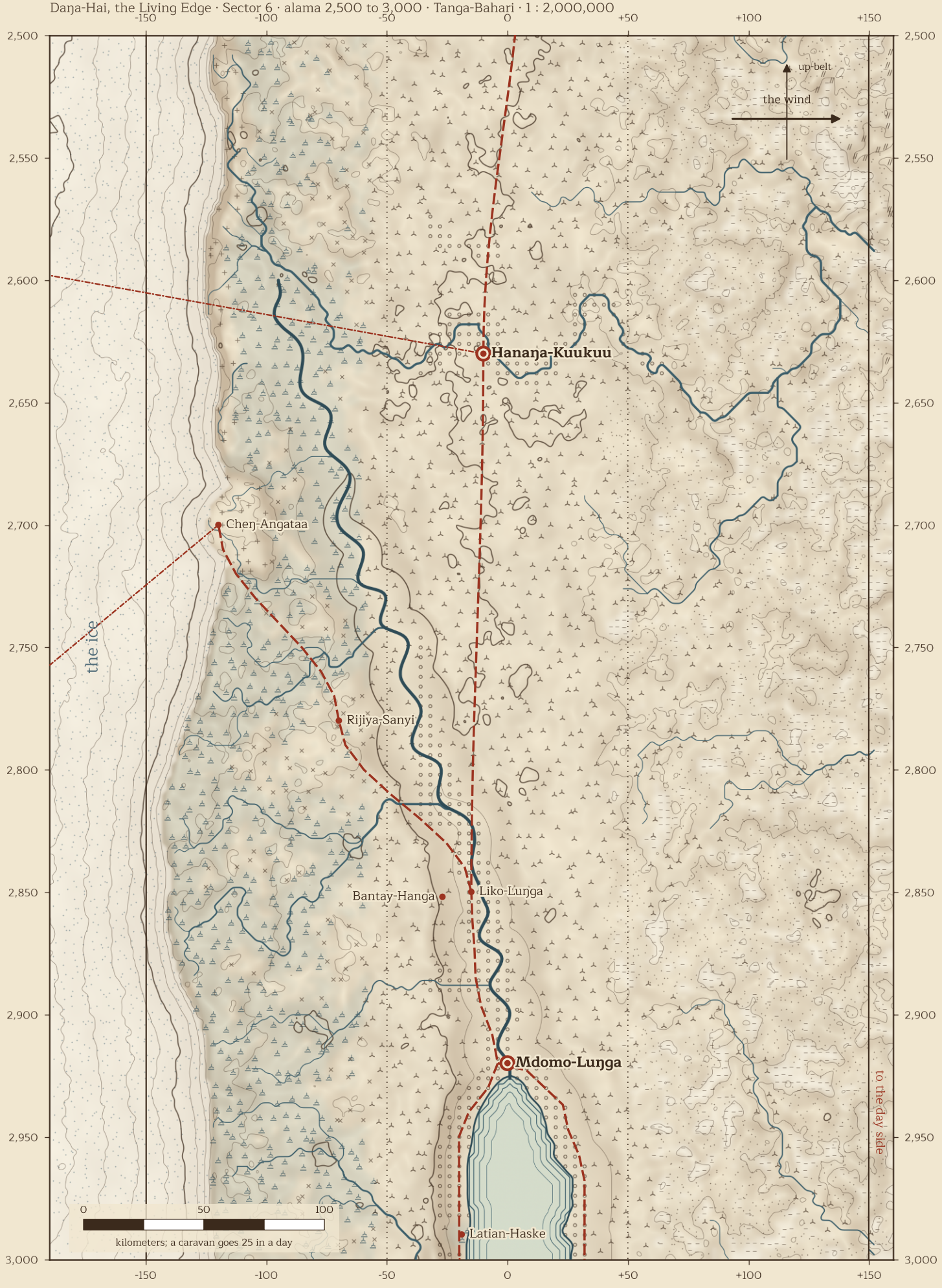
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 5 · alama 2,000 to 2,500 · Tanga-Bahari · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 4. Down-belt: sheet 6. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 6

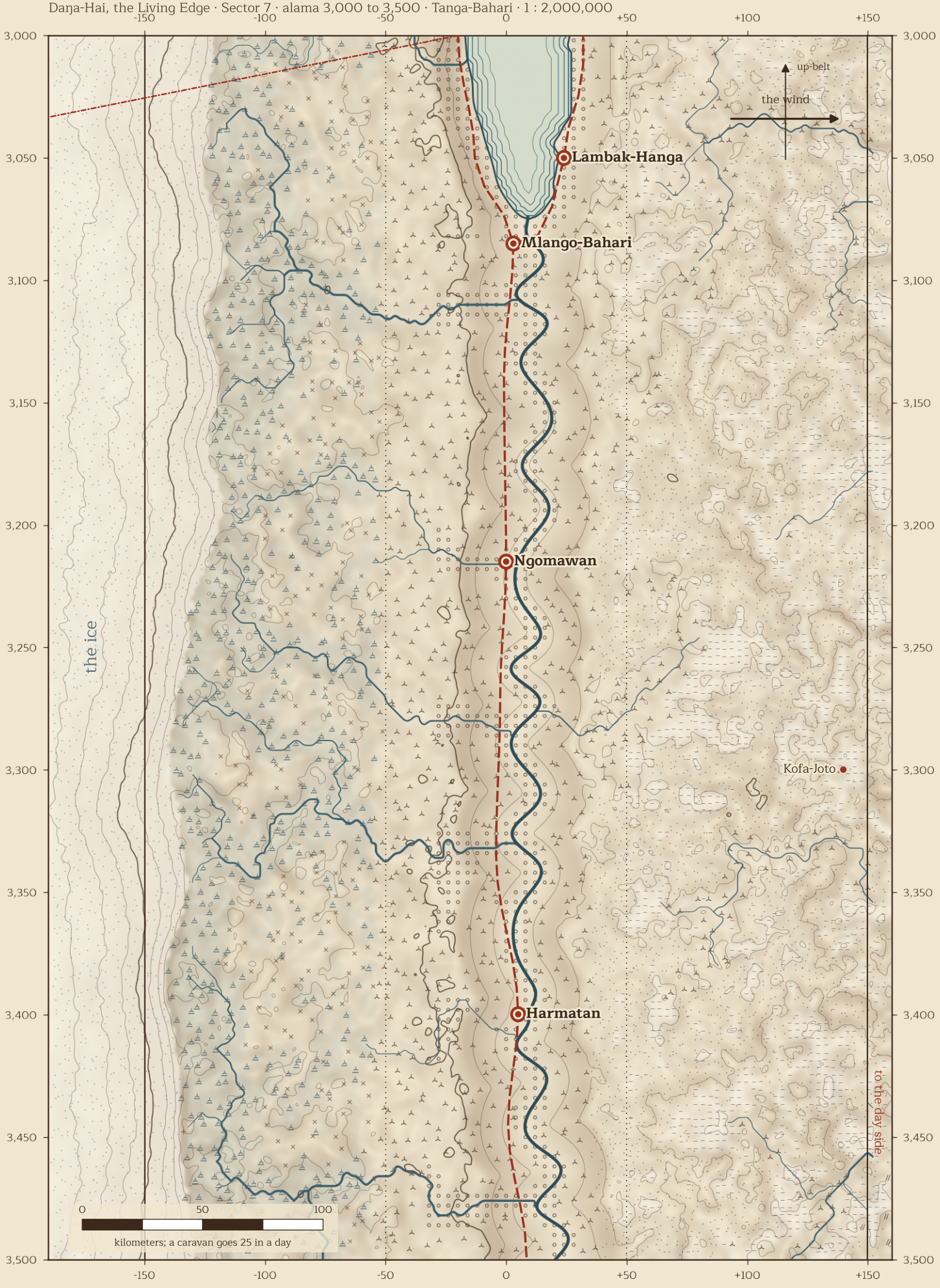
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 6 · alama 2,500 to 3,000 · Tanga-Bahari · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 5. Down-belt: sheet 7. The Bahari has a sheet of its own. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 7

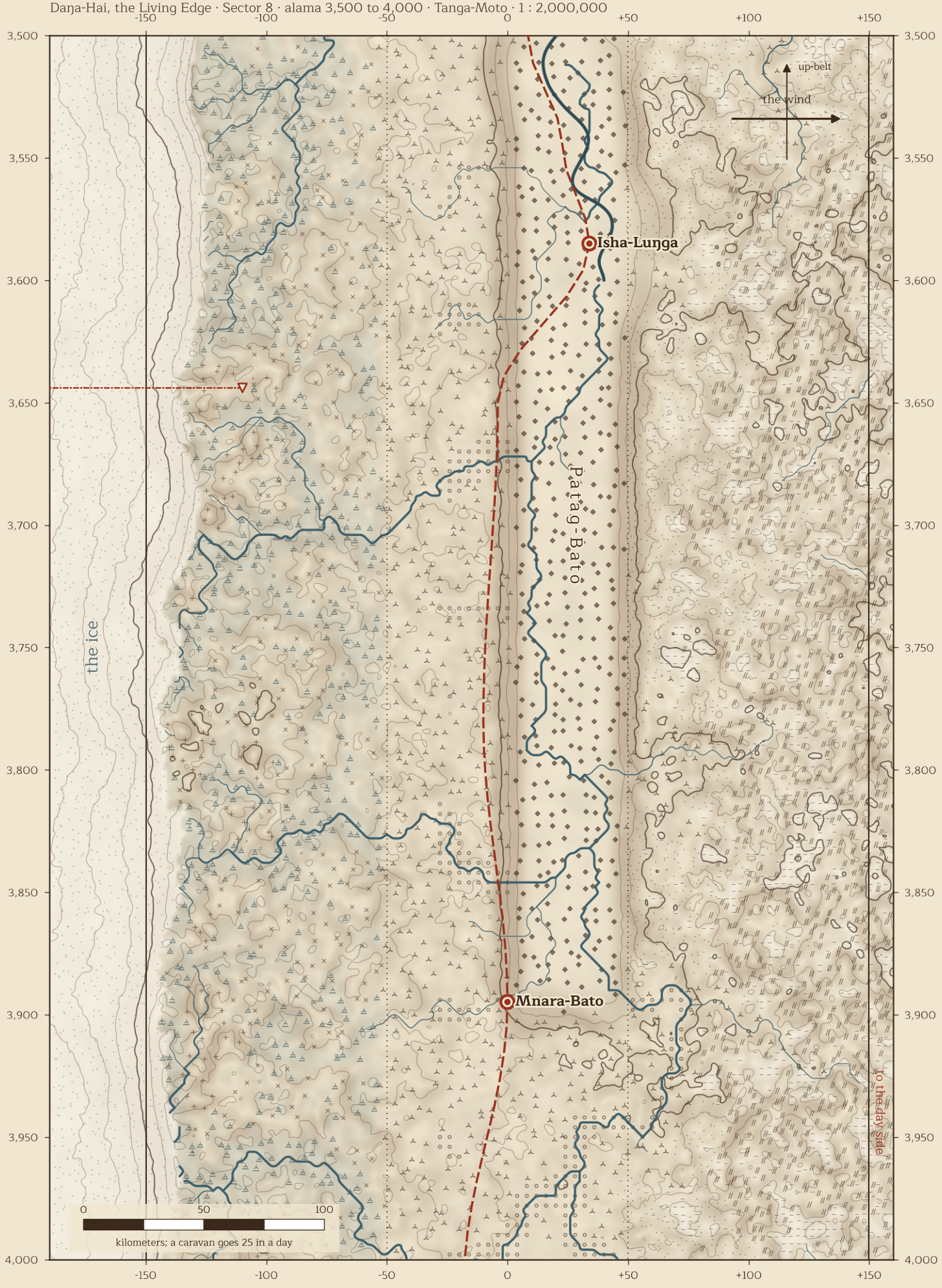
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 7 · alama 3,000 to 3,500 · Tanga-Bahari · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 6. Down-belt: sheet 8. The Bahari has a sheet of its own. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 8

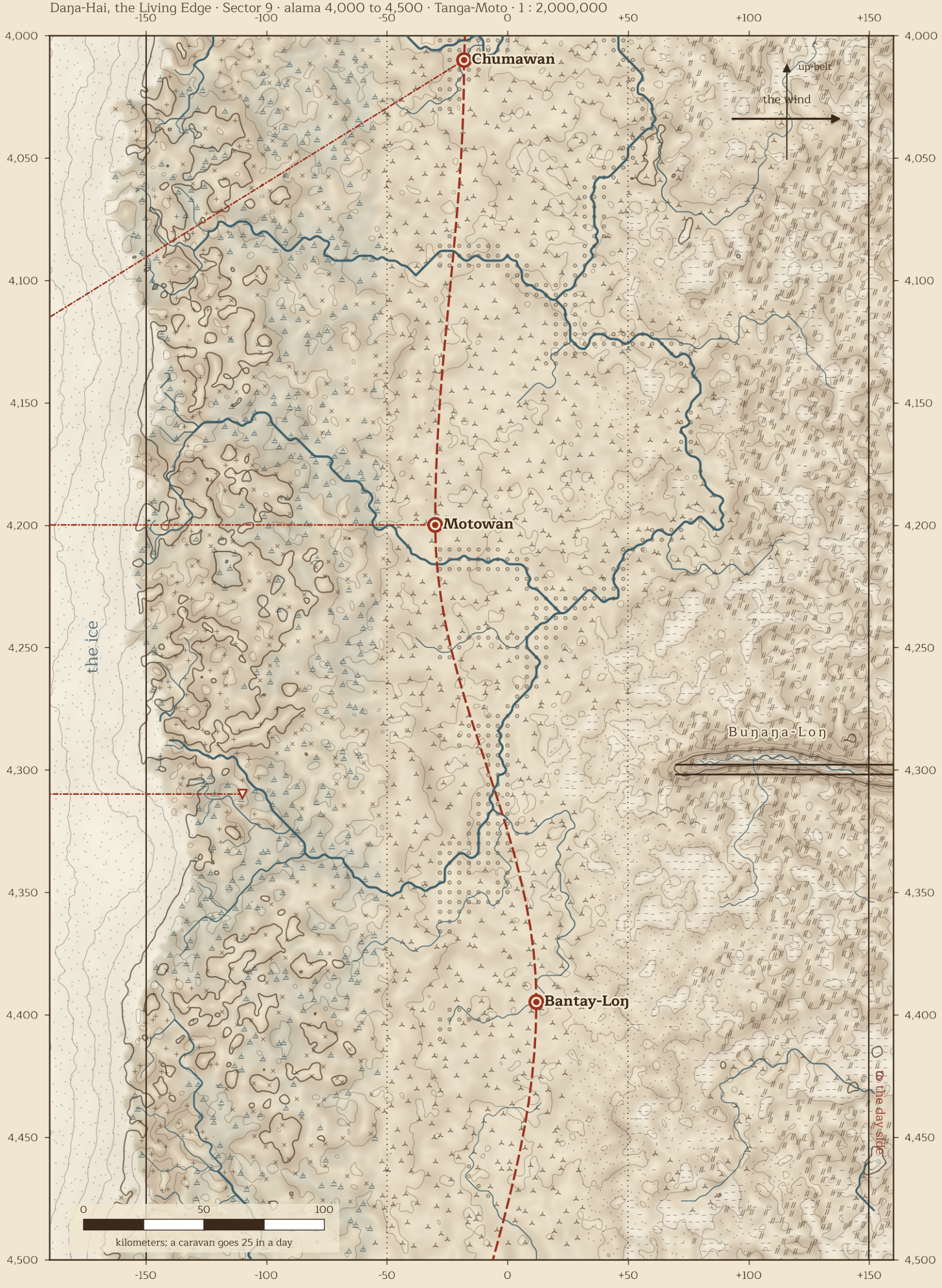
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 8 · alama 3,500 to 4,000 · Tanga-Moto · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 7. Down-belt: sheet 9. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 9

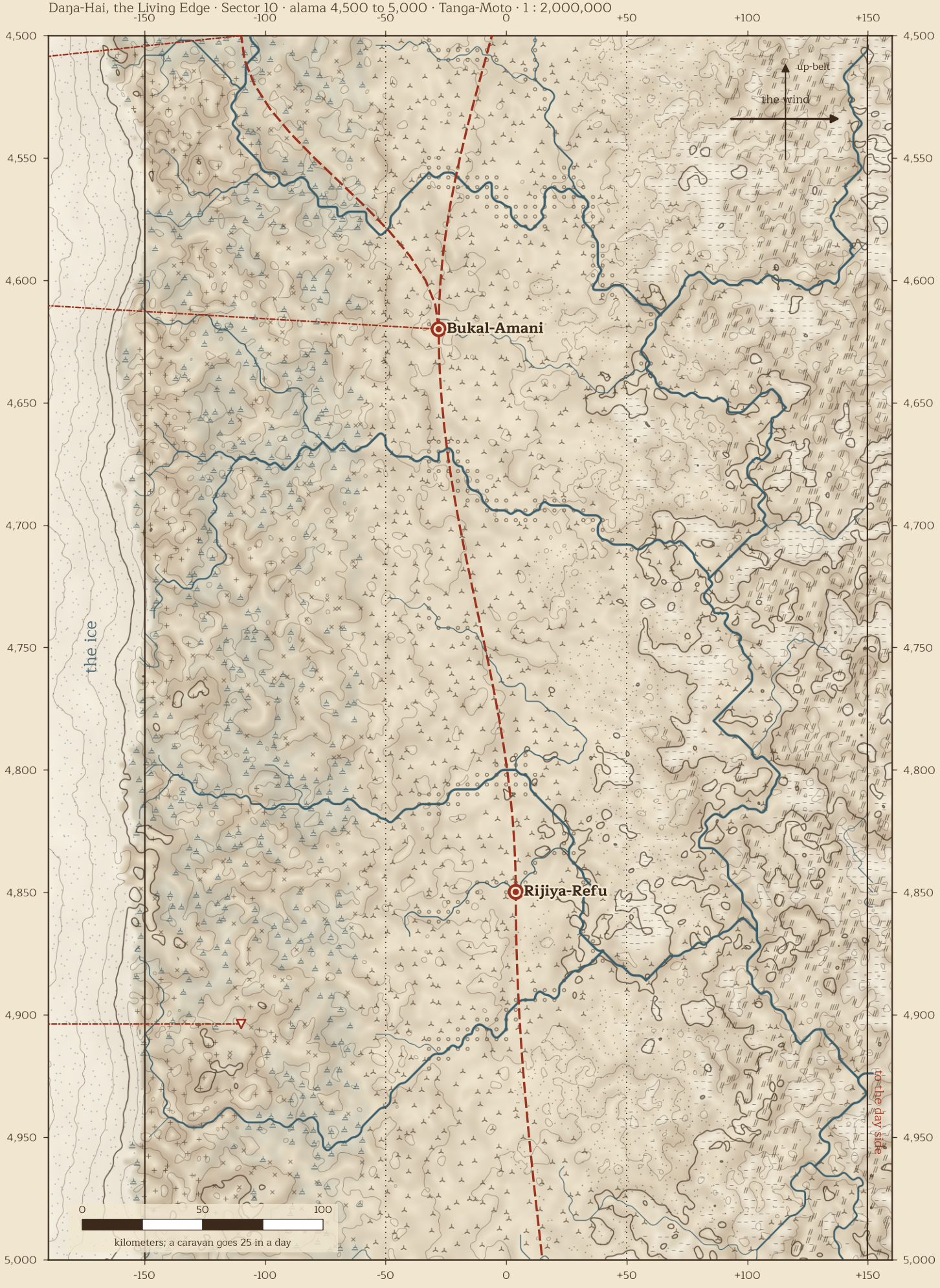
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 9 · alama 4,000 to 4,500 · Tanga-Moto · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 8. Down-belt: sheet 10. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 10

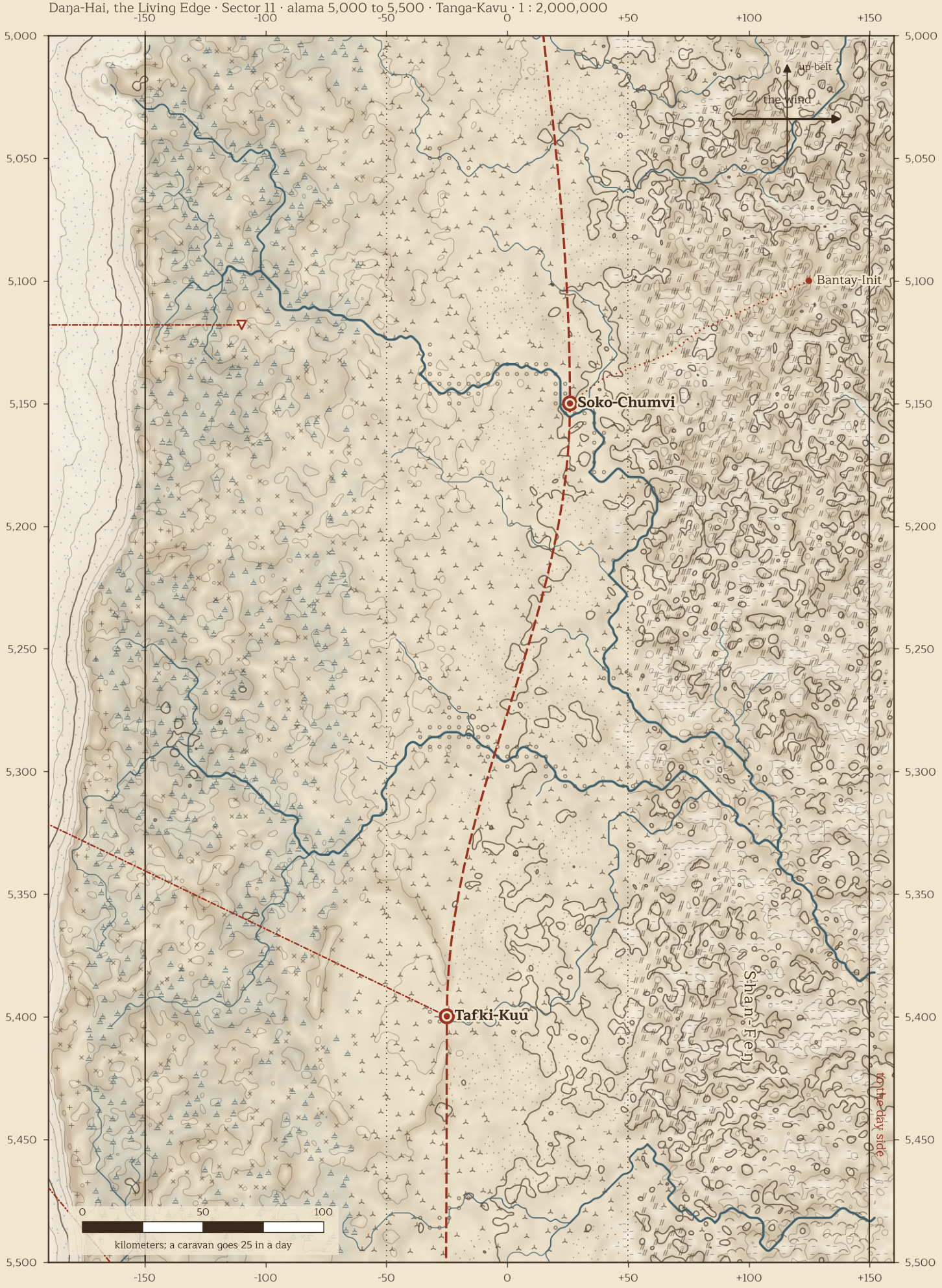
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 10 · alama 4,500 to 5,000 · Tanga-Moto · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 9. Down-belt: sheet 11. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 11

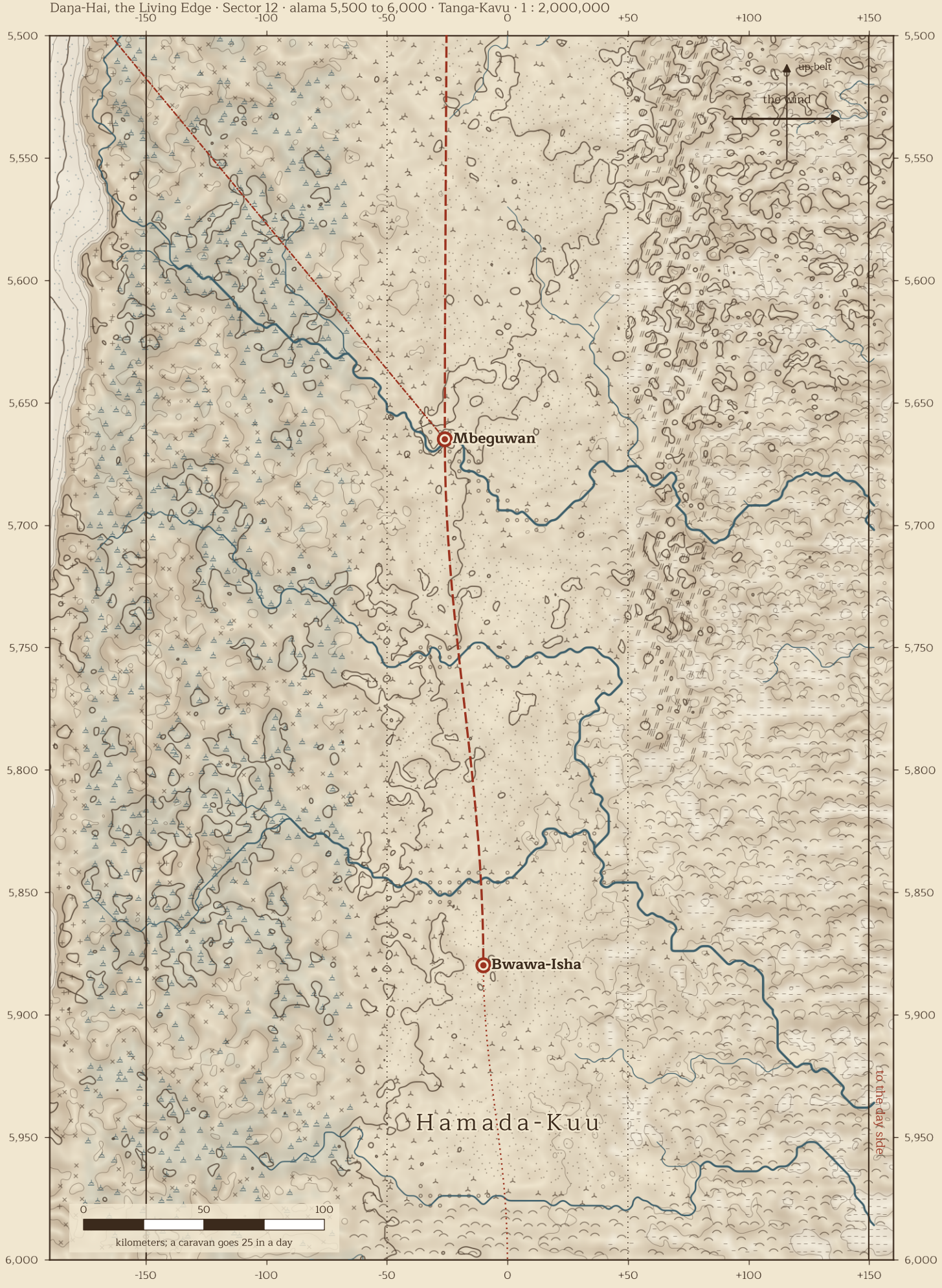
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 11 · alama 5,000 to 5,500 · Tanga-Kavu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 10. Down-belt: sheet 12. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Sheet 12

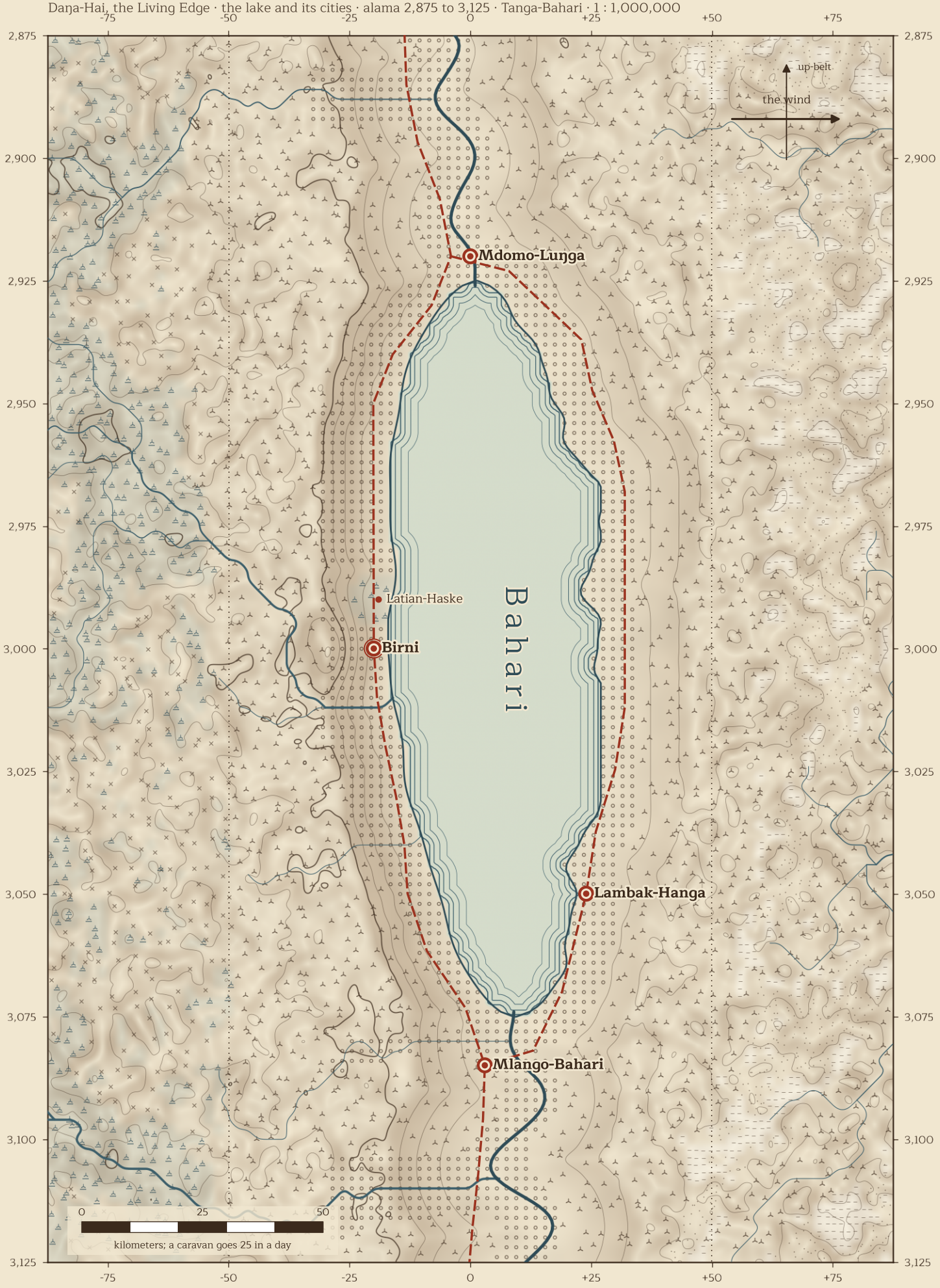
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · Sector 12 · alama 5,500 to 6,000 · Tanga-Kavu · 1 : 2,000,000



Up-belt: sheet 11. Down-belt: Hamada-Kuu; nobody has a survey beyond it. The caves beyond the Nightward Edge are on the night-side sheets. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The Bahari

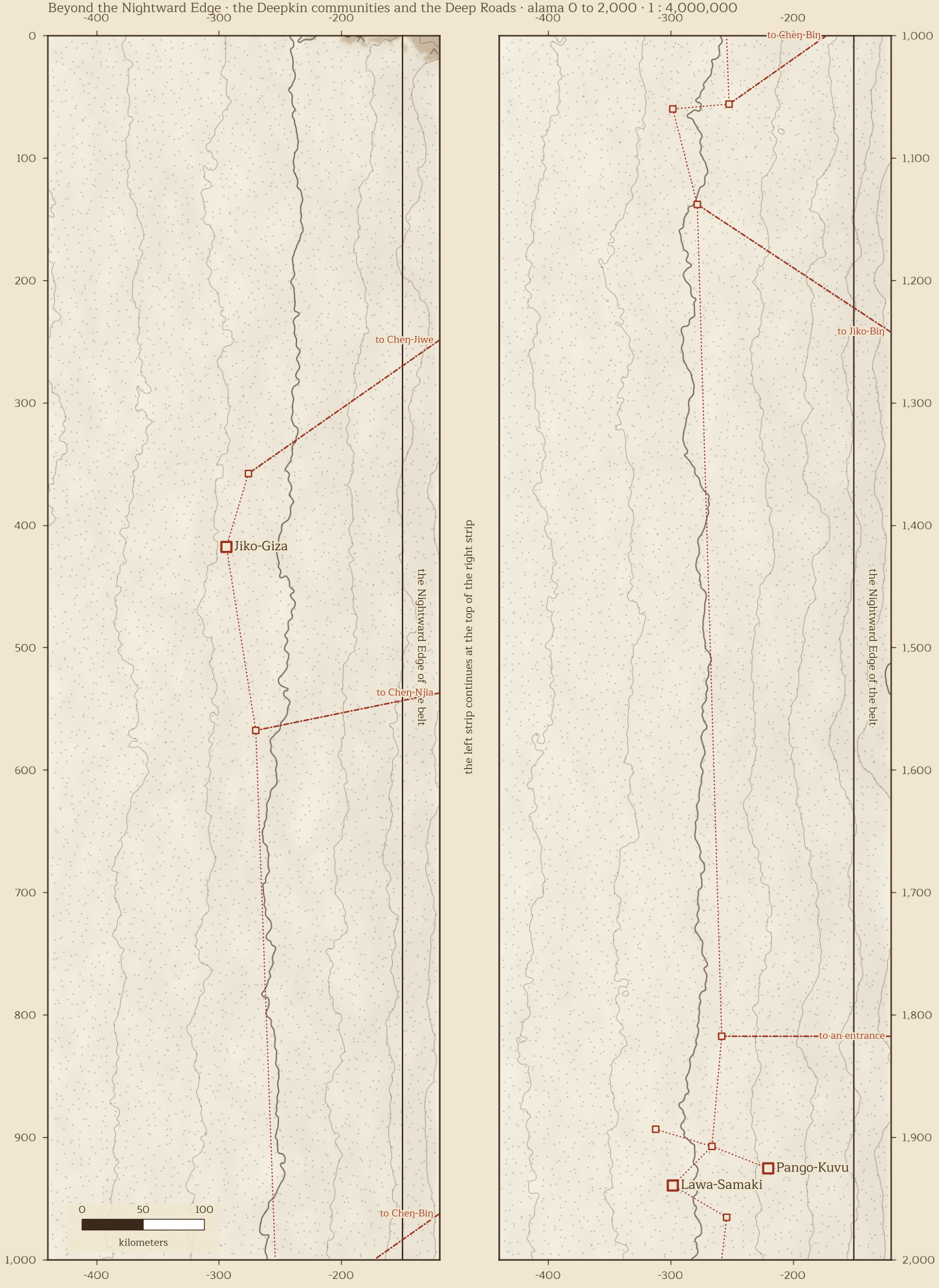
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the lake and its cities · alama 2,875 to 3,125 · Tanga-Bahari · 1 : 1,000,000



Parts of sheets 6 and 7 at twice their scale. Contours at 50 m. The survey has one height for each 2 km, so this sheet is larger, not finer. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Night side I

Beyond the Nightward Edge · the Deepkin communities and the Deep Roads · alama O to 2,000 · 1 : 4,000,000



Squares: Deepkin communities; the fifteen largest have their names. Dotted red lines: Deep Roads. Dash and dot: a tunnel to a gate on the surface. Contours of the ice at 200 m. The caves are under the ice: the chart shows where they are, not the ground above them. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

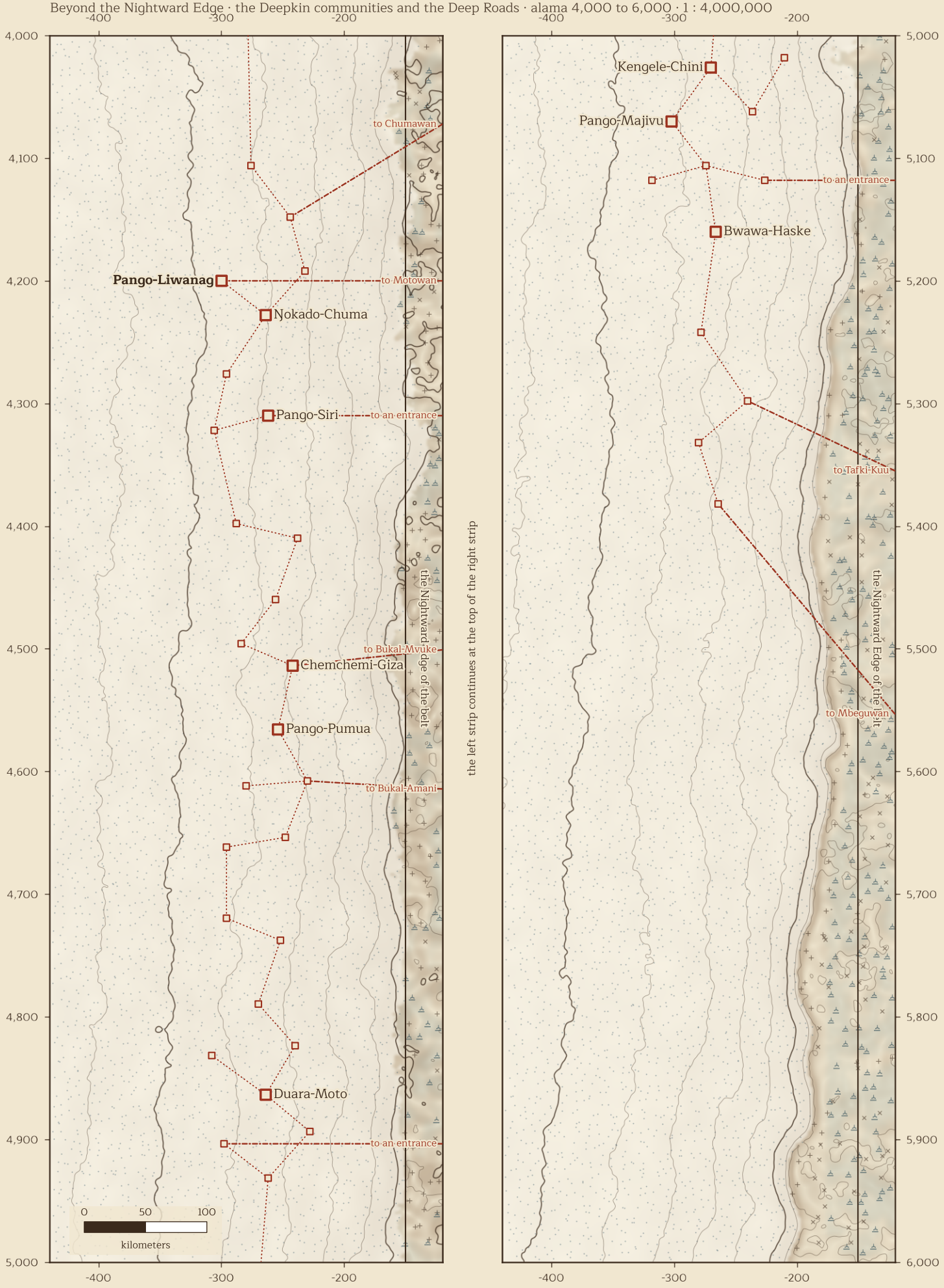
Night side II

Beyond the Nightward Edge · the Deepkin communities and the Deep Roads · alama 2,000 to 4,000 · 1 : 4,000,000

Squares: Deepkin communities; the fifteen largest have their names. Dotted red lines: Deep Roads. Dash and dot: a tunnel to a gate on the surface. Contours of the ice at 200 m. The caves are under the ice: the chart shows where they are, not the ground above them.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Night side III

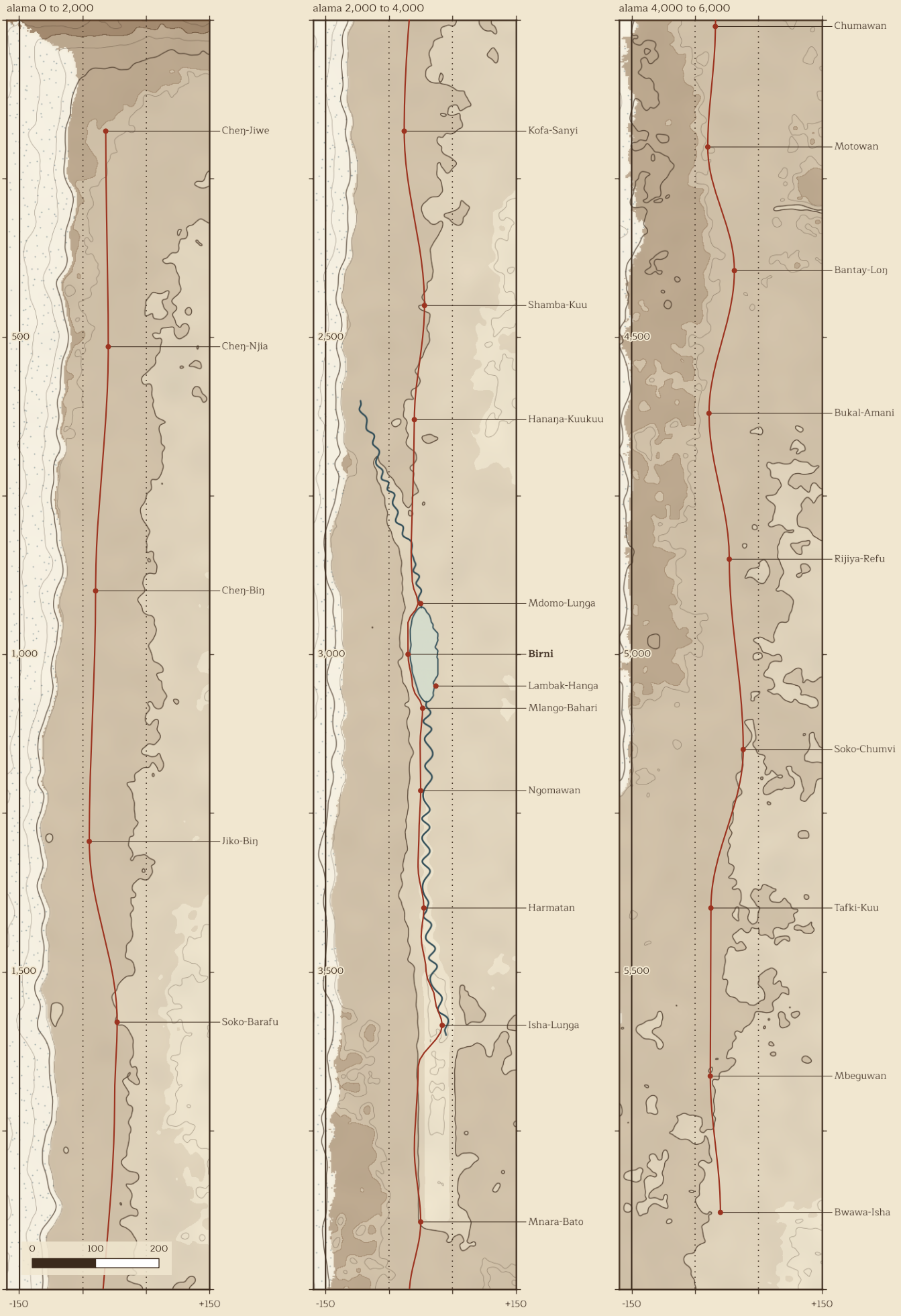
Beyond the Nightward Edge · the Deepkin communities and the Deep Roads · alama 4,000 to 6,000 · 1 : 4,000,000



Squares: Deepkin communities; the fifteen largest have their names. Dotted red lines: Deep Roads. Dash and dot: a tunnel to a gate on the surface.
Contours of the ice at 200 m. The caves are under the ice: the chart shows where they are, not the ground above them.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The heights

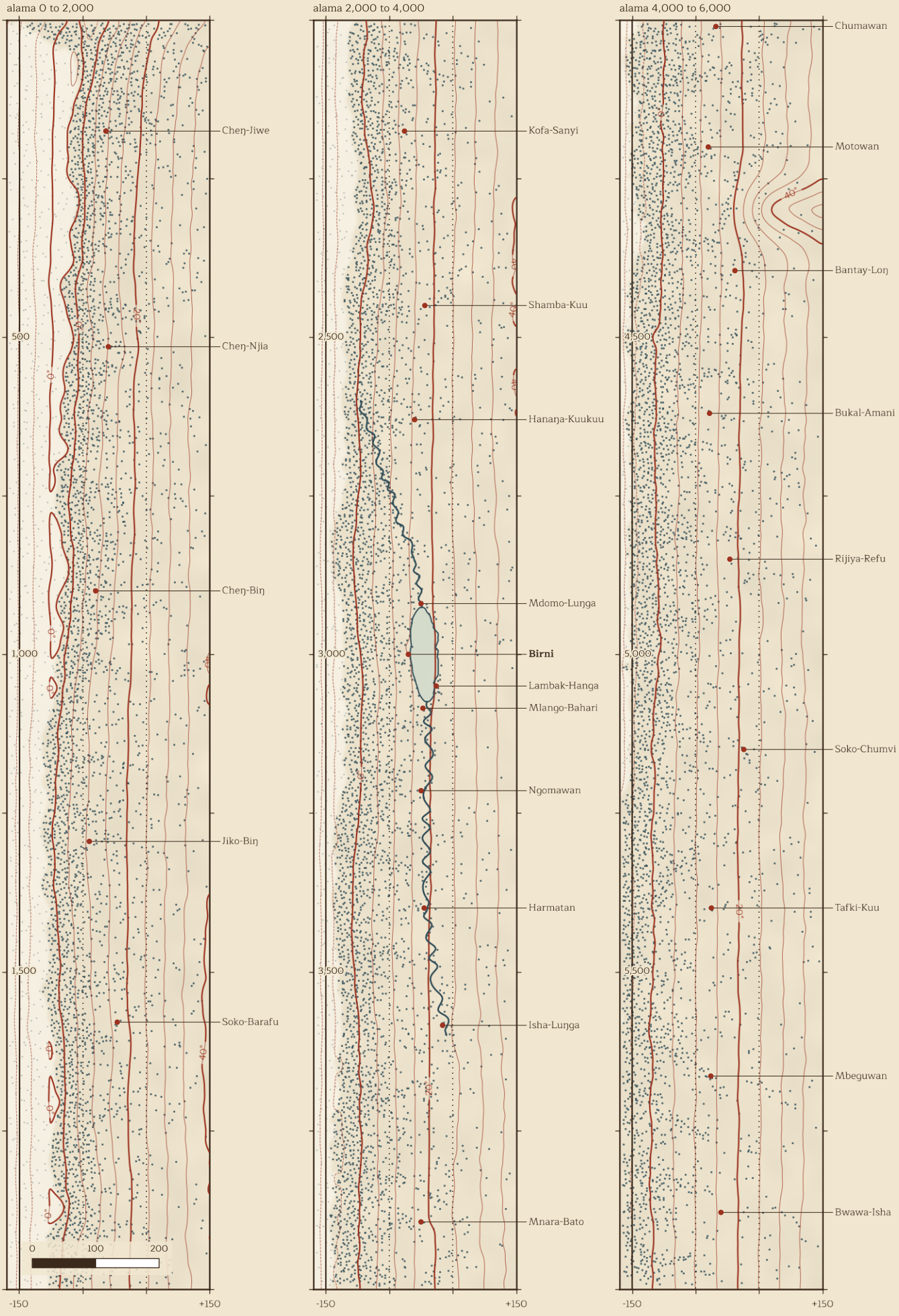
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the height of the ground · 1 : 8,000,000



Tone of the ground: paper below 300 m, then four tones of brown, from 300 m, 500 m, 800 m and 1,500 m. Contours each 250 m; heavy at 500, 1,000, 2,000 and 3,000 m. The ground falls from the ice to the day side. The rift of the heartland holds the Bahari and both branches of the Luŋga-Hanga. Red line: main Whisper Road. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Warmth and water

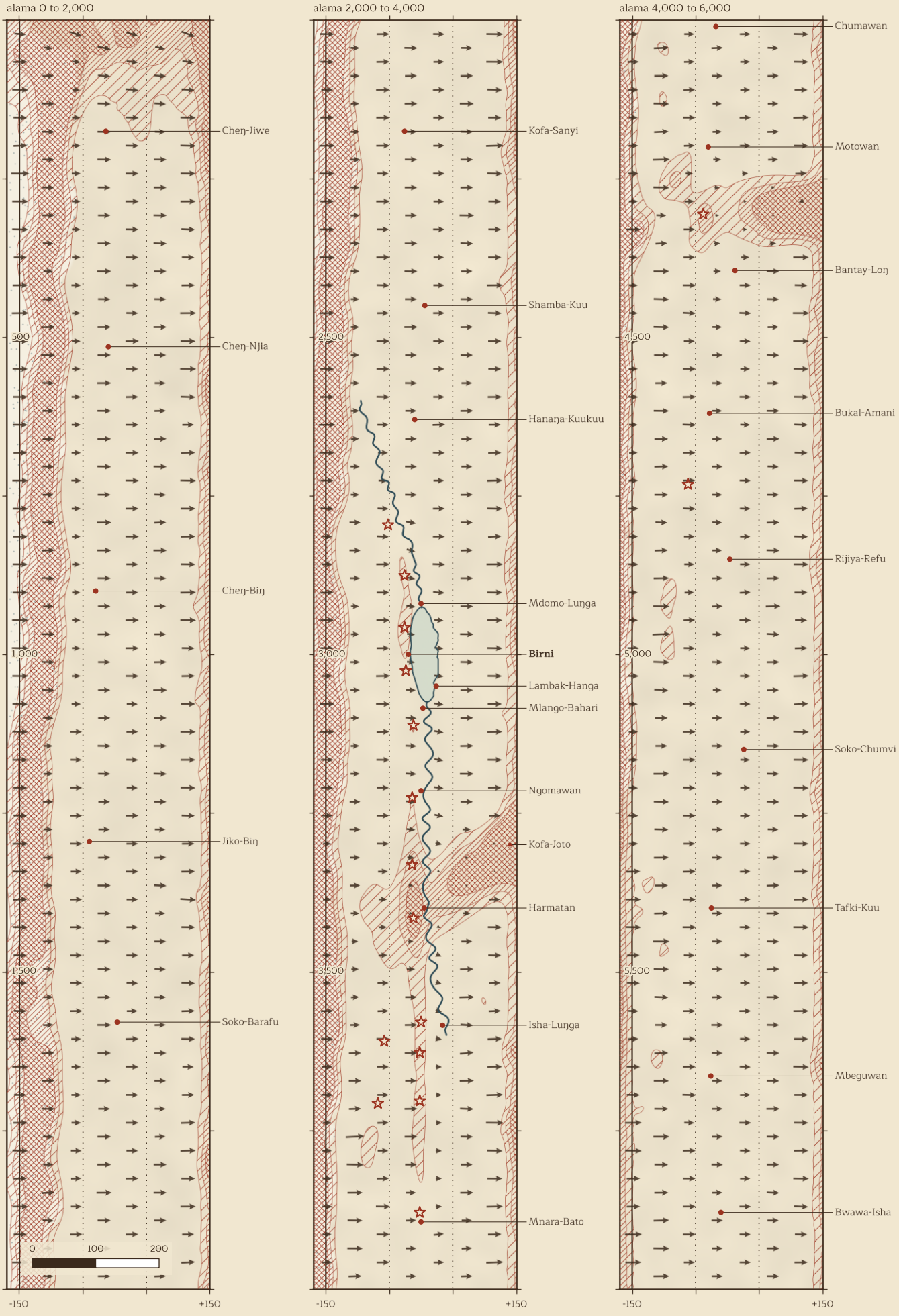
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the usual warmth of the air, and the water in the ground · 1 : 8,000,000



Red lines: equal warmth, one line for each 5 degrees; the heavy lines are 0, 20 and 40 degrees. The belt goes from about -5 degrees at its nightward edge to +40 at its dayward edge.
Grey-blue dots: water in the ground and in the air. Close dots are wet ground; paper with no dots is dry. Wind-grain does not grow in the open below 12 degrees.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The wind and the storms

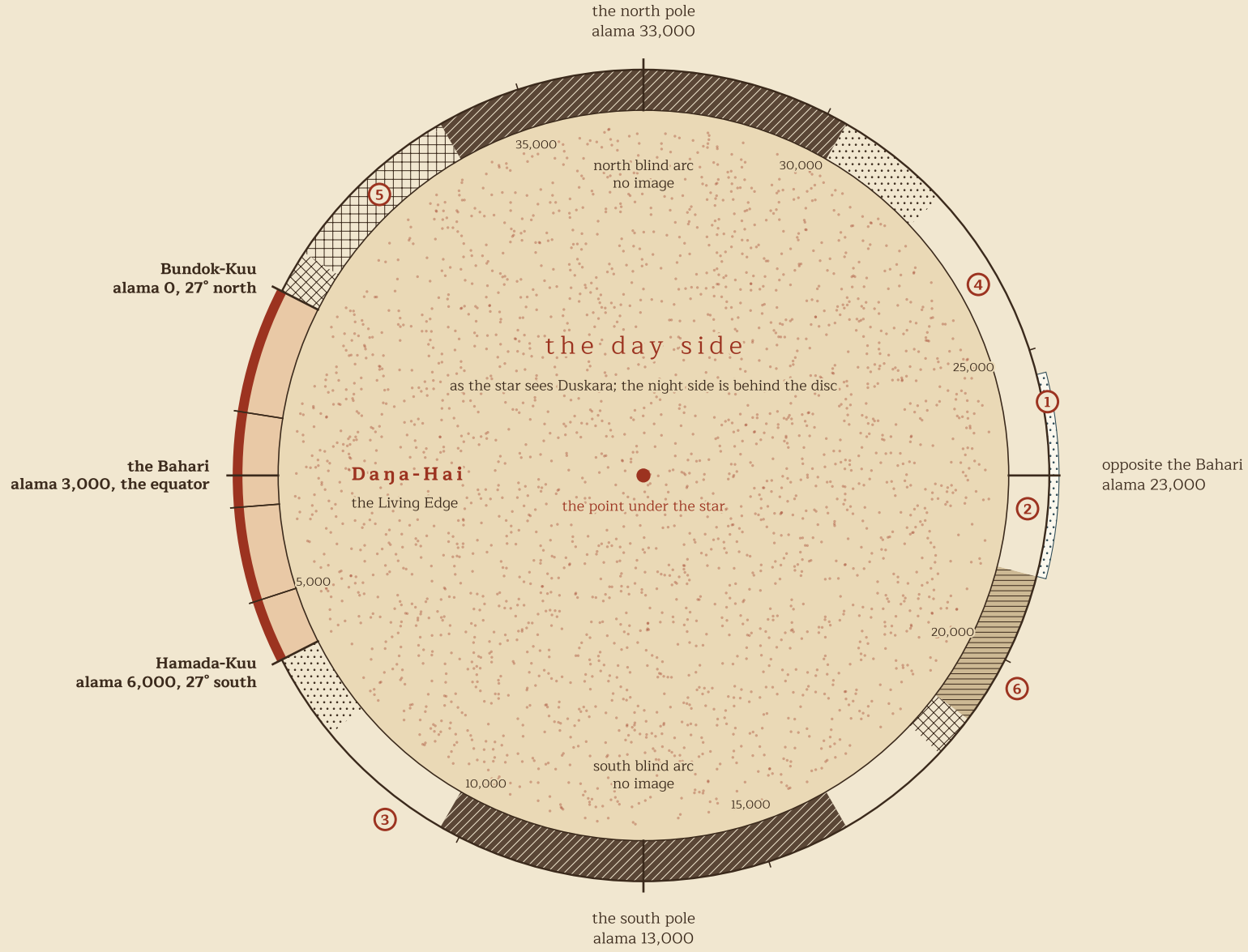
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the usual wind at the ground, and the places that the storms strike · 1 : 8,000,000



Arrows: the usual wind at the ground. It blows from the night side to the day side, and a longer arrow is a faster wind. Red stars: wind focal points, where three currents meet. Red hatching: storm exposure. Open lines: high. Close lines: severe. Crossed lines: the storm walls. Hot air comes in at Kofa-Joto and at Buŋaŋa-Loŋ, against the cold wind. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The Far Edge

The whole belt as a ring · Daŋa-Hai and the 34,000 km beyond it · from the old images of the satellites



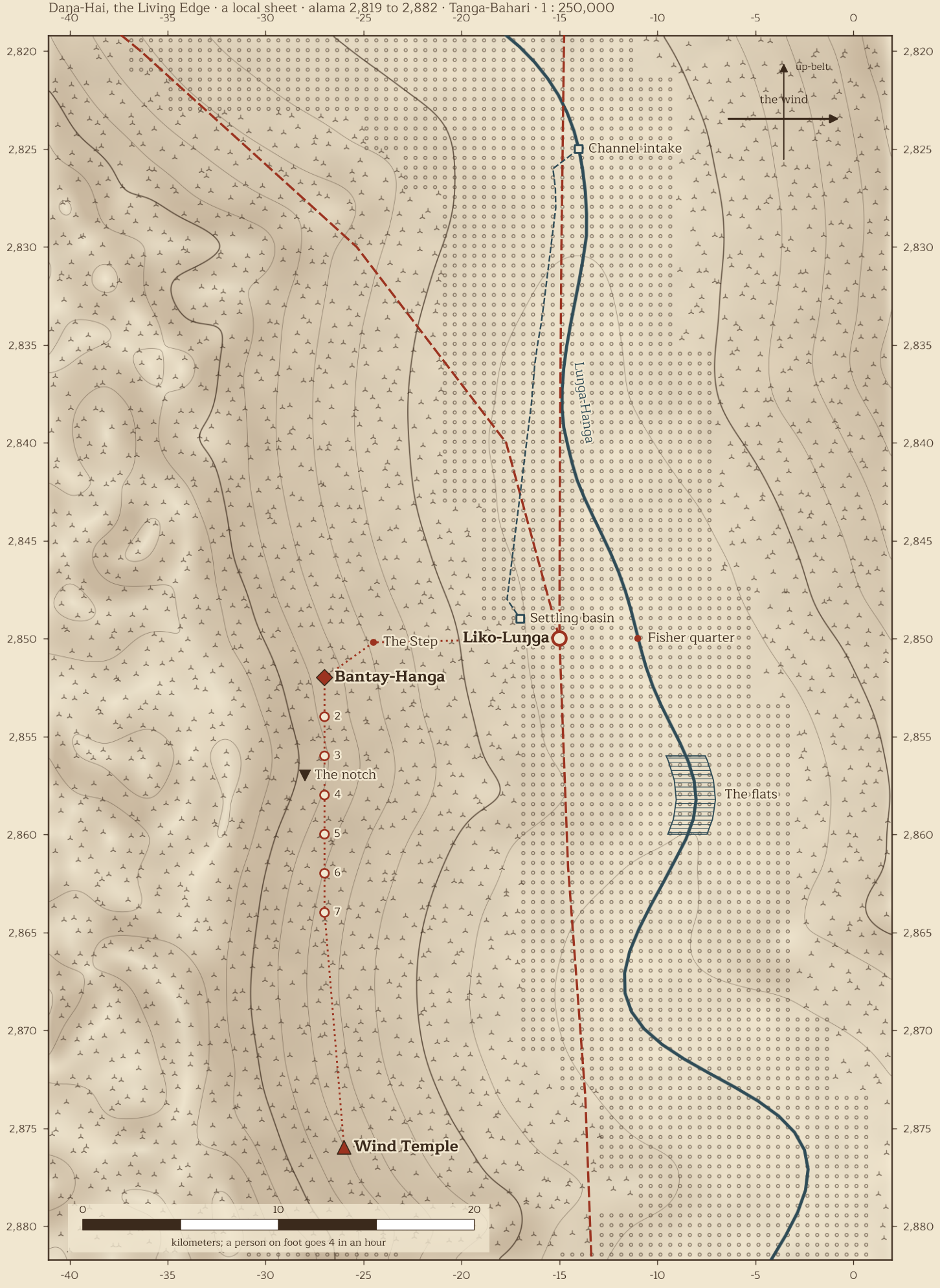
The six marks that nobody can explain

1. The Pale Arc, alama 21,400 to 24,600, night side, beside the belt. Pale ground along the night side for 3,200 km, opposite the Living Edge and at the same latitudes.
2. The Straight Line, alama 22,450, across the belt. A dark line about 40 km long, with no bend, across the belt inside the Pale Arc.
3. The Warm Point, alama 8,900, night side, about 120 km from the belt. A point that is warm in two images, made many Cycles apart.
4. The Ring, alama 26,300, in the belt. A circle about 12 km across, with a clear edge.
5. The Mark that Moved, alama 37,800, in the belt, behind Bundok-Kuu. A small dark mark that is in two places, 9 km apart, in two images.
6. The Light, alama 19,700, night side, beside the dark plain. One point of light on the night side, in one image only.

The belt is drawn 50 times wider than it is. The numbers inside the ring are alama: the count goes on round the ring, and alama 40,000 is alama 0.
The old satellites fly low over the equator, so there is no image beyond 60 degrees of latitude. The Gazetteer gives the readings of each mark and does not choose between them.
From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Liko-Lunga and Bantay-Hanga

Dana-Hai, the Living Edge · a local sheet · alama 2,819 to 2,882 · Tanga-Bahari · 1 : 250,000



Contours at 20 m. Red dots: foot paths. Blue dashes: an irrigation channel. Blue lines in a box: low ground by the river. Numbered circles: storm havens. Main channel: 25 km. Scarp path: 13 km. Shelf path: 12 km. Temple path: 12 km. The survey has one height for each 2 km: this sheet is larger, not finer. From the Accord surveys. A chart of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

The Plates

The Plates show what a map is too large to hold: a city street by street, a growing tower floor by floor, the inside of a storm haven when the wall comes through, the hand of a water judge, the hearth of a Deepkin family. They are in five groups.

- Land and Sky: plates 1 to 3
- Cities and Towns: plates 4 to 9
- Buildings: plates 10 to 16
- Daily Life: plates 17 to 20
- Under the Night: plates 21 to 21

Land and Sky

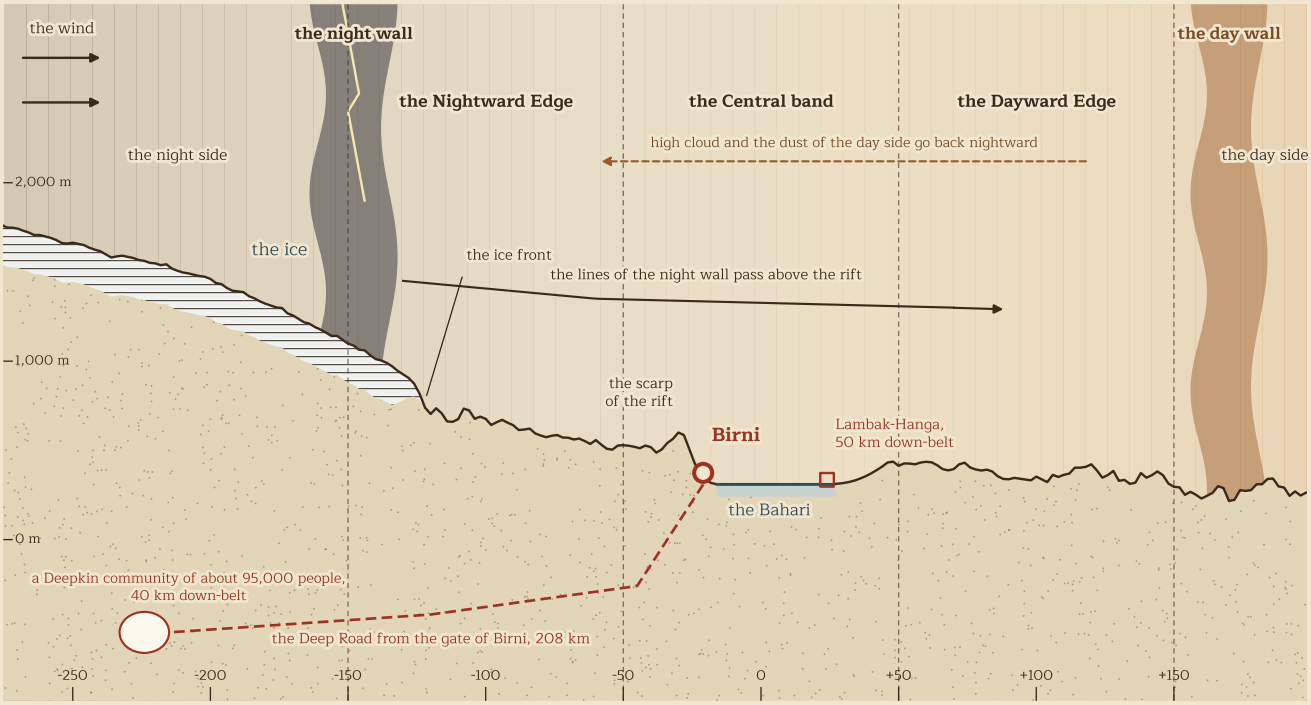
The first three plates set the stage. The cut across the belt shows the order that every town follows, from the ice to the salt, with the wind always blowing toward the day. The sky shows what a Duskaran sees overhead: a star that never moves. The Whisper Road shows how people and goods travel the length of the arc.

Plate 1 The Belt Across
Plate 2 The Sky
Plate 3 The Whisper Road

Plate I

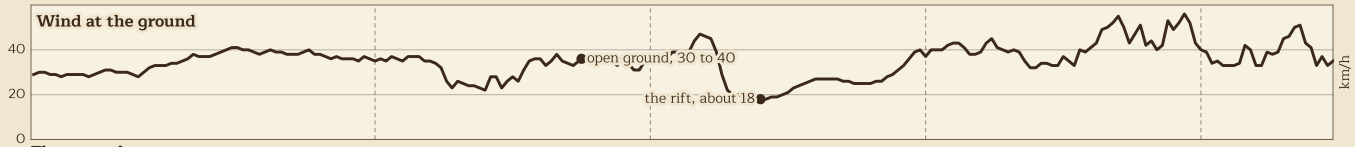
The Belt Across

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the belt from the night to the day at alama 3,000, through Birni · lengths 1 : 2,750,000

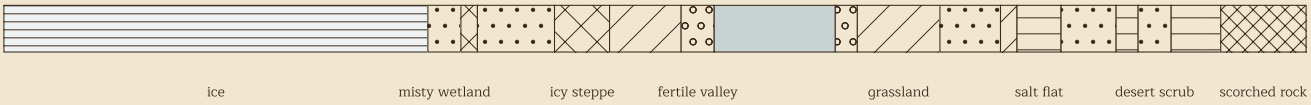


The Lion on level ground, as each band sees it

The line at 12: wind-grain does not grow in the open below it.



The ground



The Nightward Edge

-150 to -50 km

The rim of the sun or none, and the aurora; the blue-green of moss and fungi at the ground. Cold and wet, with mist, and the wind off the ice. The ground rises toward the ice. Ice harvest, frostbloom tea, Deepkin traders at the gates.

The Central band

-50 to +50 km

The country where the ground cuts the sun. Here it holds the rift and the Bahari: the mildest air of the arc, mist on the water, the road of red light on the lake. Birni rises from the nightward shore and faces the sun across the water.

The Dayward Edge

+50 to +150 km

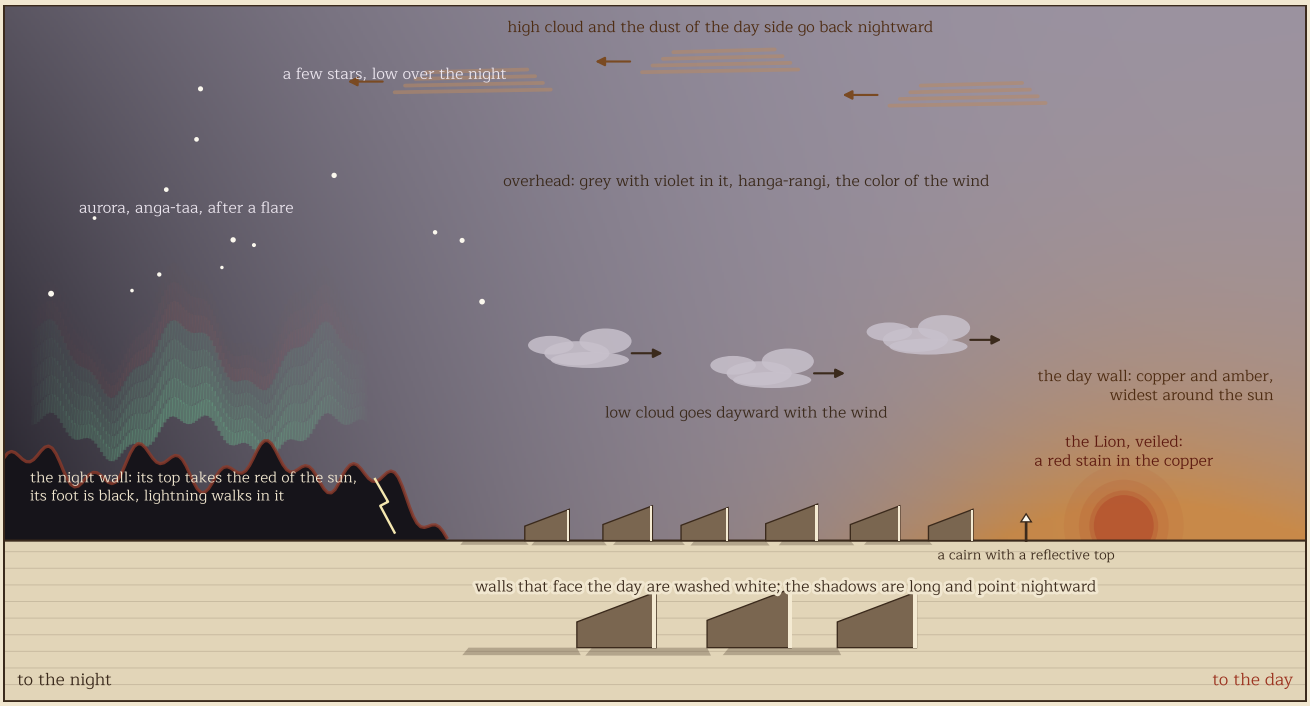
The whole sun, and glare from the salt. Hot, up to 40 degrees, and dry. Scrub, badlands and salt flats. Outposts and nomads; work in the cooler phases; eyes covered.

Heights are drawn 65 times taller than lengths; the model has one height for each 2 km. The thickness of the ice, the depth of the lake and the depth of the Deep Road are not surveyed: they show where these things are, not their size.
From the Accord surveys. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

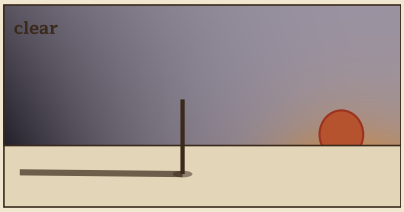
Plate 2

The Sky

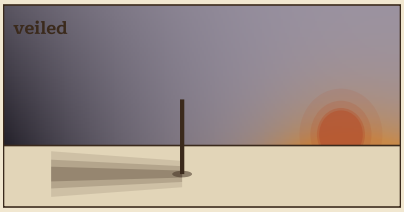
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the sky of a heartland town, looking up-belt: the night on the left, the day on the right



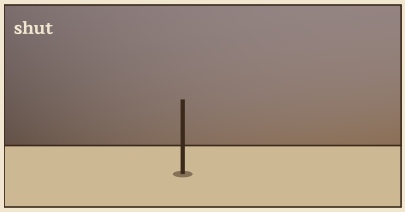
The three states of the sun



The disc is hard and red, and every shadow has an edge.



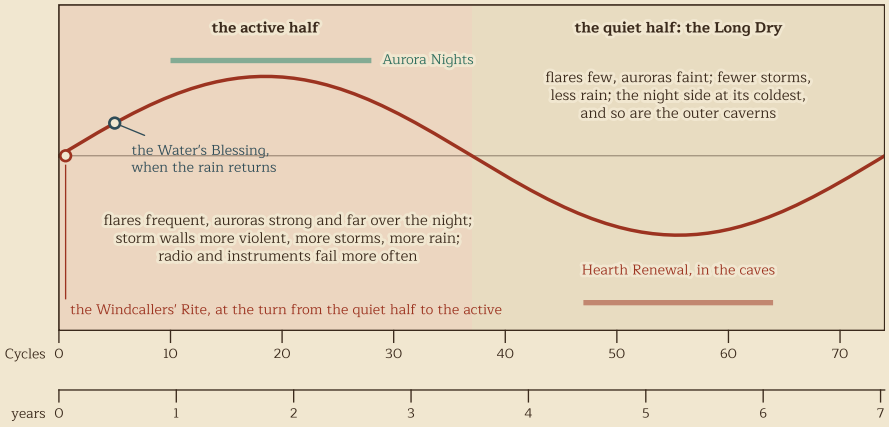
The usual state in the Central band. The disc is a red stain in the copper, and shadows are soft.



A dust phase. There is no disc for days: the light turns brown, and nothing has a shadow.

The star's breath, pumzi-nyota

The Lion's activity rises and falls over about 74 Cycles. The change in its light is too small to see; its effects are not.



Light on the ground

- The sun does not move. Shadows do not move: every wall has a lit face and a dark face for all time.
- The light does not change with the bell, only with the weather: a line of storm, a dust phase, mist off the lake.
- A person who walks nightward walks on their own shadow; one who walks dayward has the light in the eyes.
- Moss, damp and frost keep to the dark face. Things dry on the lit face.
- Copper bands in a storm cloud are the dust of the day side coming down.
- No moon.

Cloth in the low red light

Red, ochre, yellow and white are strong. Blue and green look dark.

The disc of the sun is drawn larger than its true size, which is one finger at arm's length. The star's breath is drawn as an even curve; years are the Archivists' count.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

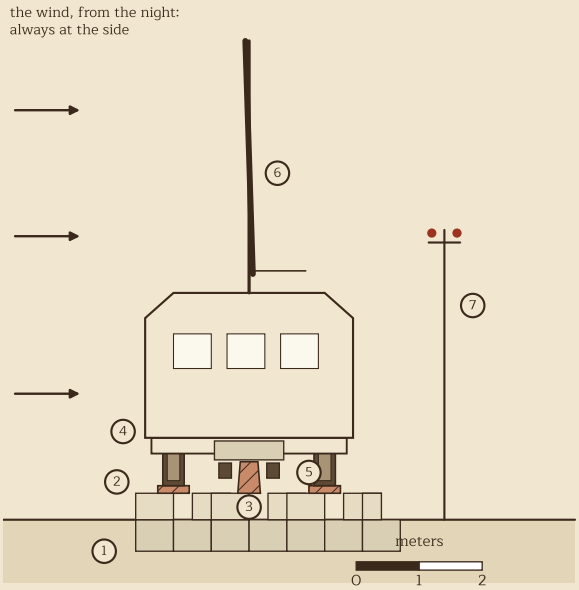
Plate 3

The Whisper Road

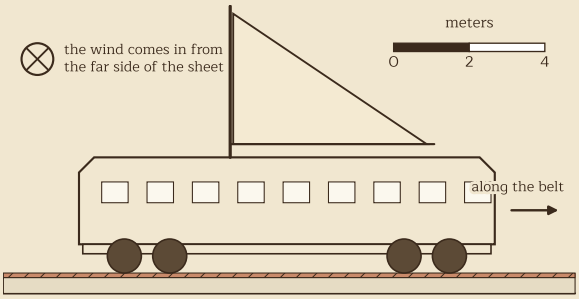
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the wind rail: its line along the arc, its guideway and its carriage

The main line and its branches · alama on the left of the line

The carriage on the guideway, end-on · 1 : 120



The carriage from the side · 1 : 200



1 The bed

Dressed stone. A damaged stretch is mended with the stone at hand.

2 The running plates

Fired ceramic. The rail shows as a bright line across the country.

3 The center rail

Raised, of the same ceramic. The guide wheels hold it, and it steers the carriage.

4 The wheels

Tires of plant composite. The line needs almost no metal.

5 The motor

Charged by the wind. Power goes first to pumps, growing towers, rail and public works.

6 The sail

The carriage runs under sail and on its motor. The wind comes from the side whichever way it goes.

7 The Thread

Text only, from station to station; a message crosses the arc in a day or two.

On the road

- A carriage runs at 30 to 40 km an hour while it moves. It stops at every junction and waits out every storm, so it makes about 150 km in a day.
- By caravan the same journeys take 10 to 12 days, about 20 days, about 4 Cycles and about 8 Cycles.
- Between adjacent major cities, about 2 days; across one sector, 3 to 4 days; from either end of the arc to the Bahari, about 20 days; the whole arc, about 40.
- The crews of Cheŋ-Njia go out after each storm to mend the line and the Thread anywhere on the arc. A city that wants a new junction comes to its rail guild first.

Red rings: the major cities on the main line. Bars: halts. Black rings: the branch lines to Cheŋ-Angataa, along the dayward shore of the Bahari, and to Bukal-Mvuke. Red dashes: the Thread. Days at 150 km a day, in good conditions. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Cities and Towns

A Duskaran town is laid out by the wind and the water. Look for the clean end and the used end: the air comes in on the nightward side and leaves on the dayward side, and every building takes its place along that line. Birni on its lake, Tafki-Kuu in its bowl of rock and Liko-Luŋga on the floor of the rift show how the same rule fits different ground. Sickness in the Town shows the rule at work when something goes wrong.

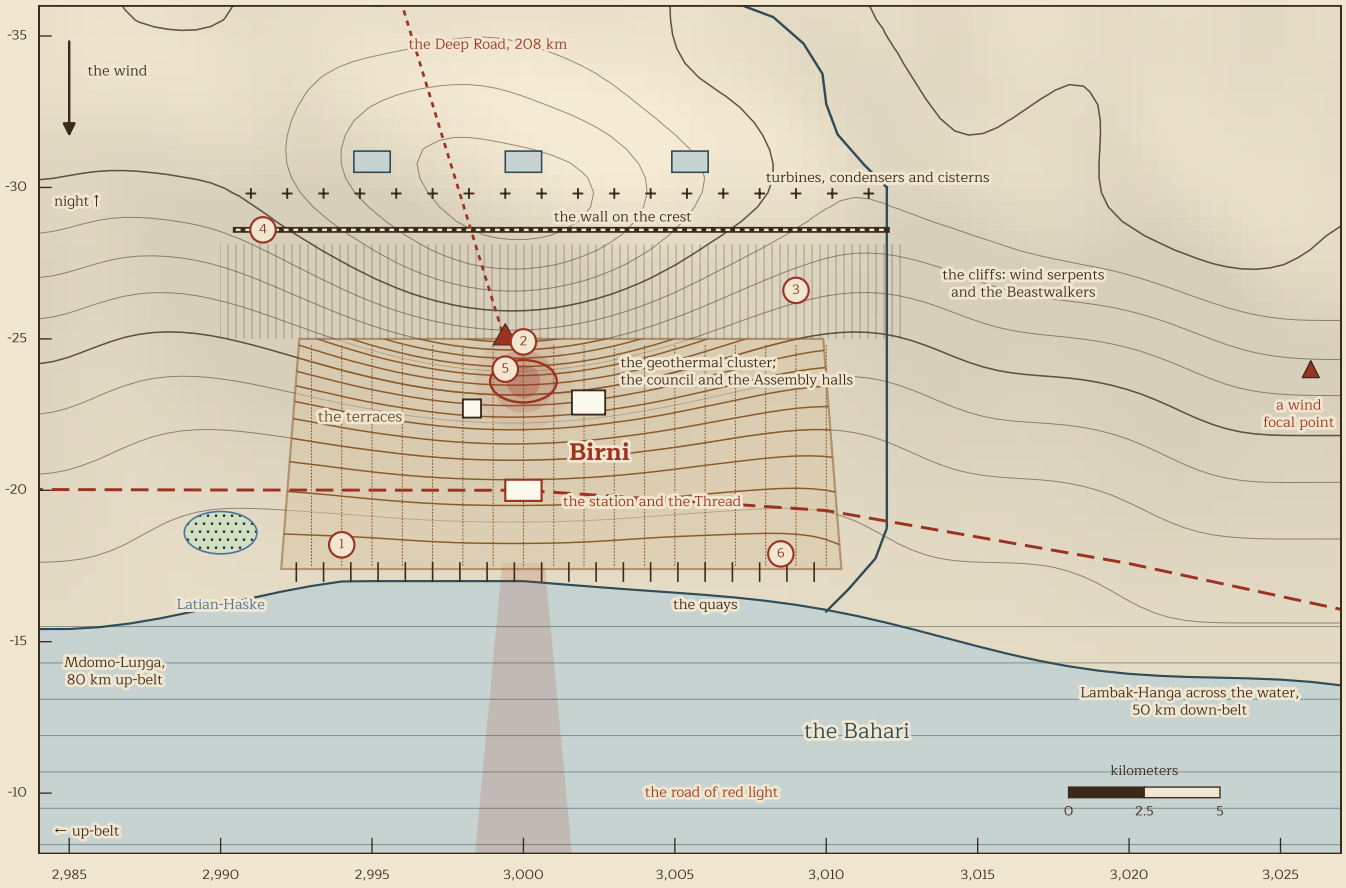
Plate 4 Birni
Plate 5 Tafki-Kuu
Plate 6 Liko-Luŋga
Plate 7 The Town across the Belt
Plate 8 A Heartland Town
Plate 9 Sickness in the Town

Plate 4

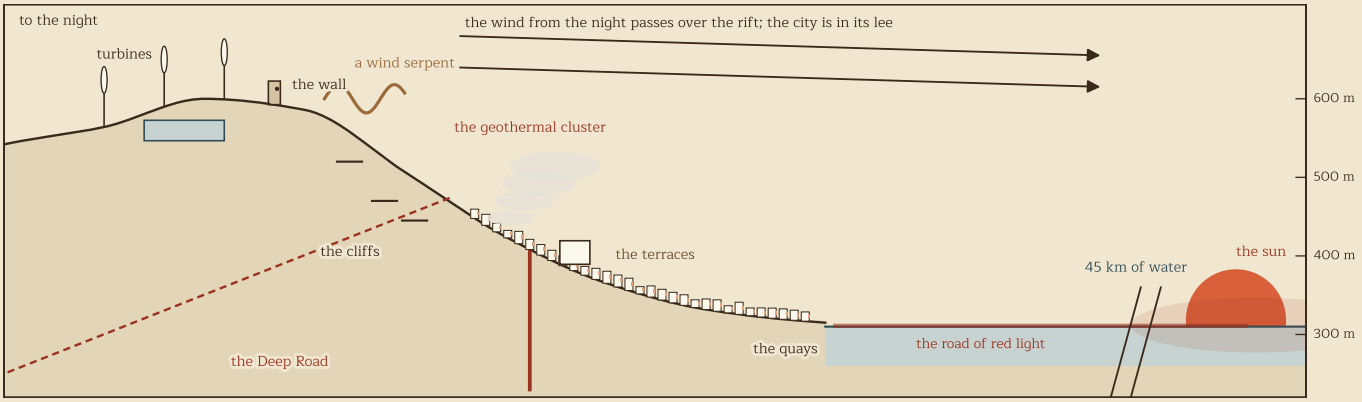
Birni

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the walled city on the nightward shore of the Bahari, alama 3,000

The city on its shore · 1 : 250,000 · contours at 25 m



Across the city at alama 3,000 · heights sixteen times the lengths



1 The terraces

The city rises from the shore toward the geothermal cluster. Each terrace follows the slope; the cross lanes go up it, with the wind.

2 The geothermal cluster

The warm heart of the city. The council hall and the hall of the Assembly stand beside it.

3 The cliffs

The scarp of the rift. Wind serpents nest on its ledges, and the Beastwalkers who bond with them live below.

4 The wall

On the crest, at the clean end of the city: the old wall that gave the name, with the turbines, the condensers and the cisterns behind it.

5 The gate

At the foot of the cliffs. The Deep Road goes 208 km to a community of about 95,000.

6 The quays

The used end is the shore: fishers, lake boats, drying racks, and the recyclers, sealed. Nothing runs into the lake.

The city

- The largest city of Duskara: about 1.2 million people. Its name means "walled city"; in treaties it is Birni-Bahari.
- It faces the sun across 45 km of water. On a clear day a road of red light lies on the lake from the far shore to the foot of the city.
- The hub of trade and governance, on the main Whisper Road and the Thread.
- To speak "like the central wind" is to speak like a person of Birni: with polish, and perhaps with pride.
- A short walk up-belt lies Latian-Haske, a wetland of glowing moss under a Warden. Entry without leave is a serious offense.

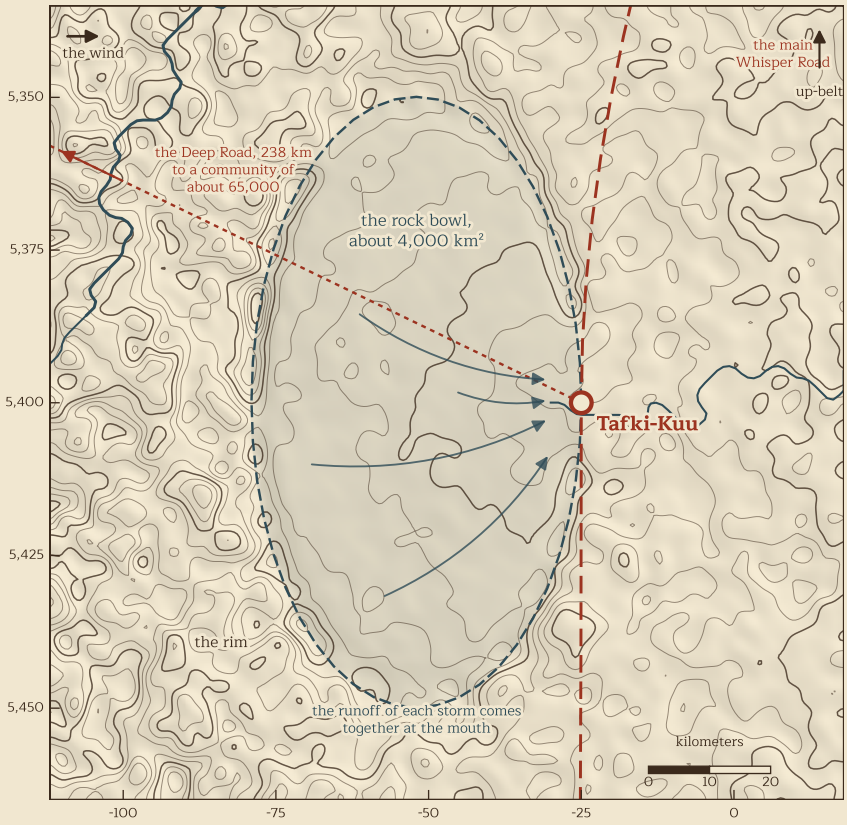
The relief, the lake, the streams and the road are drawn from the terrain model of the Accord surveys (cells of 2 km); the city is drawn over it.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 5

Tafki-Kuu

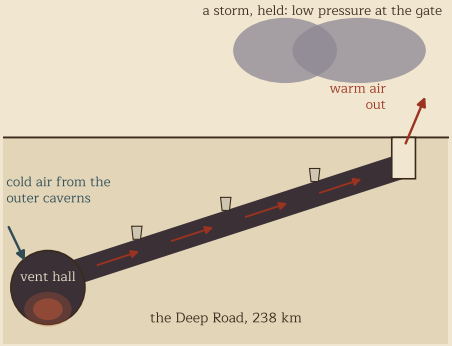
Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the city of the Great Reservoir, alama 5,400, and its rock bowl

The bowl and the city · about 1 : 1,240,000 · contours at 25 m



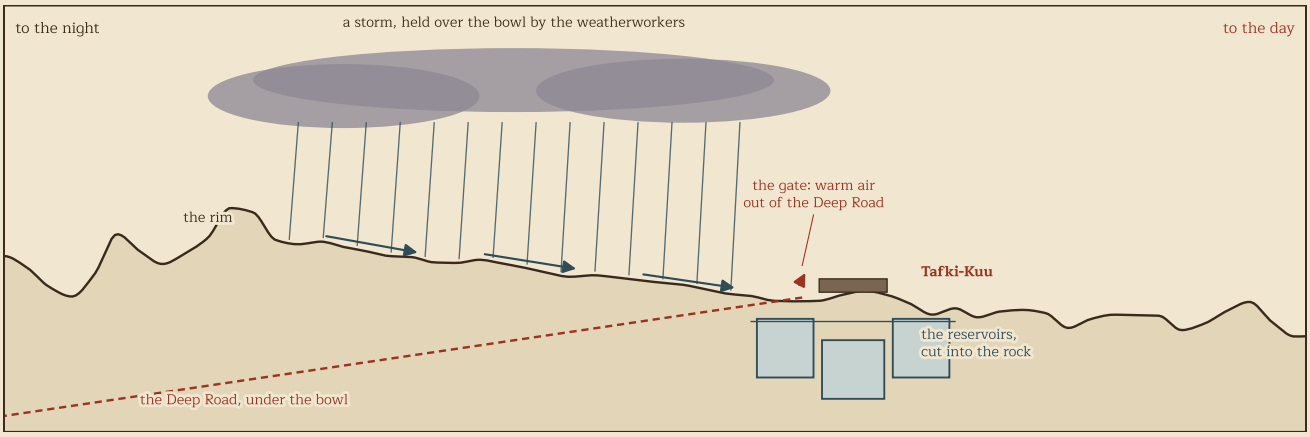
The draught of Tafki-Kuu

An open case at the gate



1. The weatherworkers hold each storm over the bowl as long as they can, so that more rain reaches the reservoirs.
2. A long hold lowers the pressure at the gate. Warm air leaves the tunnel; cold air from the outer caverns comes in at the far end.
3. In one hold the cold reached a vent hall while its weatherworkers were moving its air. The working broke, and one adept has burnout.
4. The guild: no rule asked for a warning, and the city needs every storm. The Warmth Circle: the Earth's Breath was turned back in its own house.
5. Agreed: a warning before each hold, sent down the tunnel on stone bells. Not agreed: who can answer "not now".

Across the belt at alama 5,400 · heights much exaggerated; the reservoirs and the road are not to scale



The city.

About 500,000 people, in the Central band at offset -25, on the main Whisper Road. Its name means Great Reservoir. No river reaches it: it lives on the rain of the storms that cross the bowl.

The bowl.

About 4,000 km² of rock on the nightward side of the city, open at the city, with a rim on its other sides. The runoff of each storm comes together at its mouth.

The judges.

The strictest water judges on the arc.

The market.

The chief market of the Dry Land: the minerals and the salvage of the day side come through Bantay-Init; the nomads of Shan-Feŋ trade here; expeditions into Hamada-Kuu are fitted out here and take their last water at Bwawa-Isha.

The Dry Land.

Each city lives on what it stores. A smaller measure, the strictest judges, a cloth over the mouth in the dust phases; grit on the walls and the echo of cisterns.

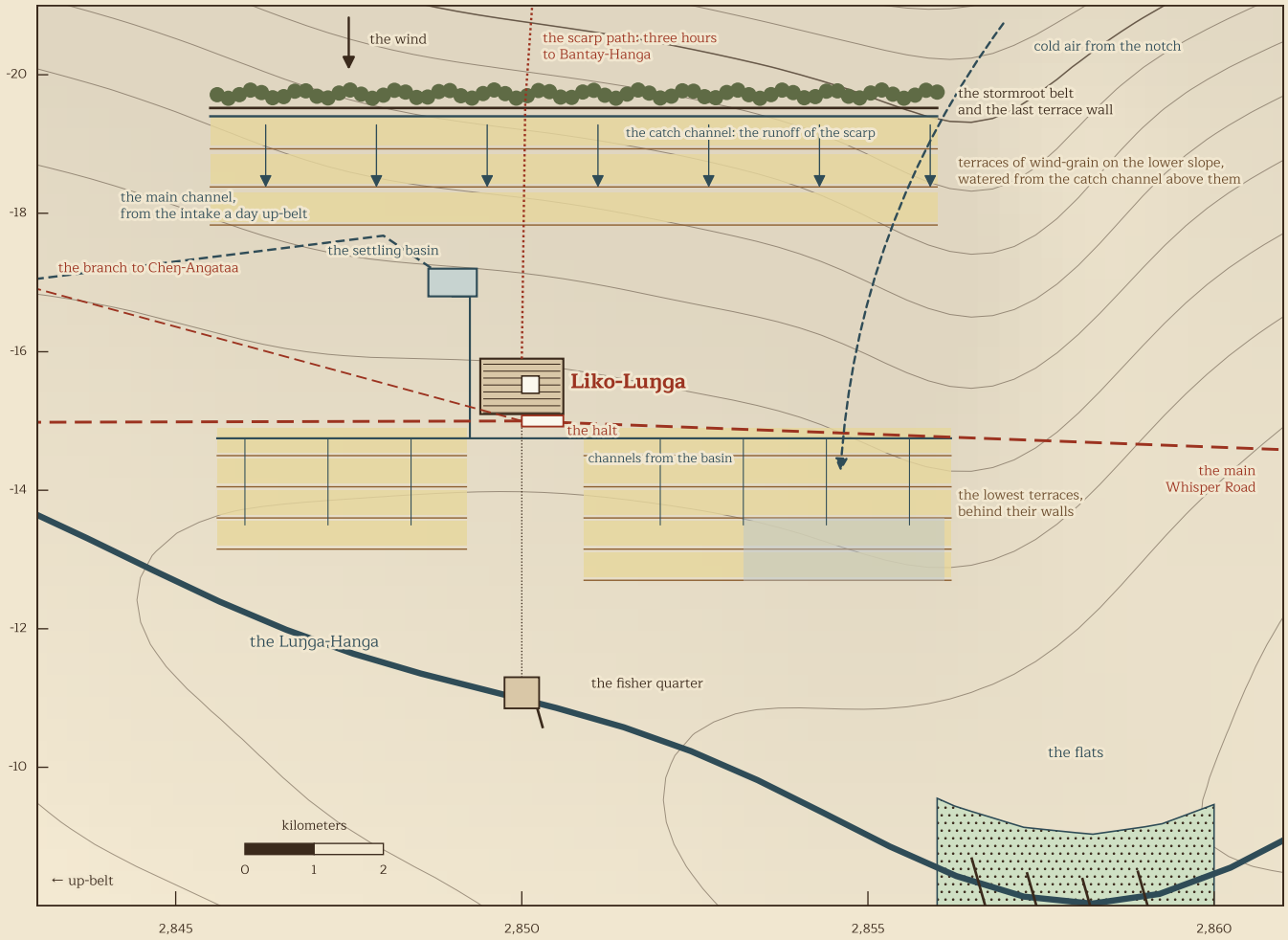
The map and the section are drawn from the terrain model of the Accord surveys (cells of 2 km); the streams are those of its flow model. From the Accord surveys. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 6

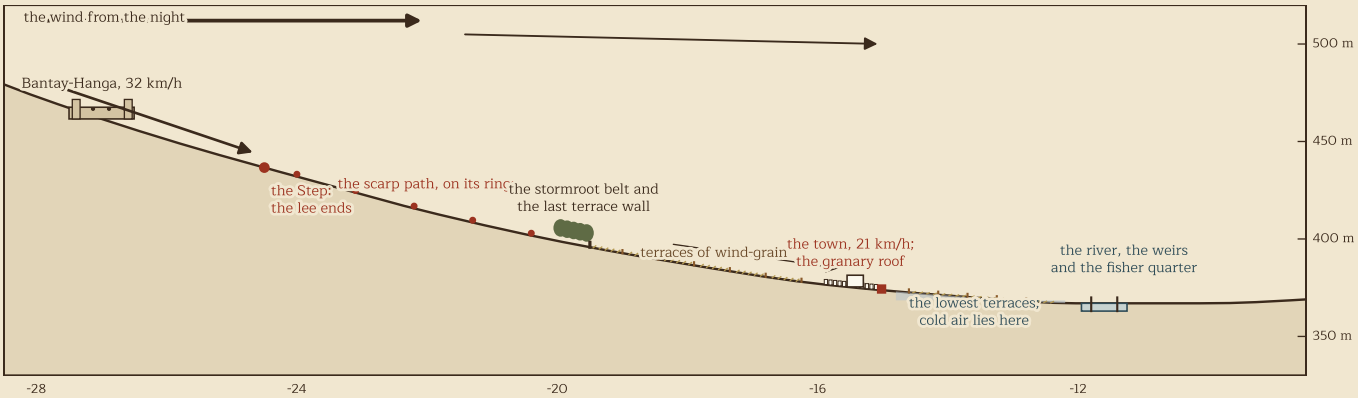
Liko-Lunga

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the farming town on the floor of the rift, alama 2,850

The town and its ground · 1 : 100,000 · contours at 5 m



From the house to the river at alama 2,850 · heights fifty times the lengths



On foot and by road

From the river to the town.

4 km: an hour on foot, through the terraces of the floor.

From the town to the house.

12 km and 110 m up: an hour of long legs, an hour more to the Step, most of an hour on the level shelf.

From the town to the flats.

6 to 10 km down-belt, along the river.

From the town to the intake.

A day on foot up-belt, along the main channel.

By Whisper Road.

Mdomo-Lunga, 70 km down-belt; Cheŋ-Angataa by the branch, up-belt and nightward.

The town

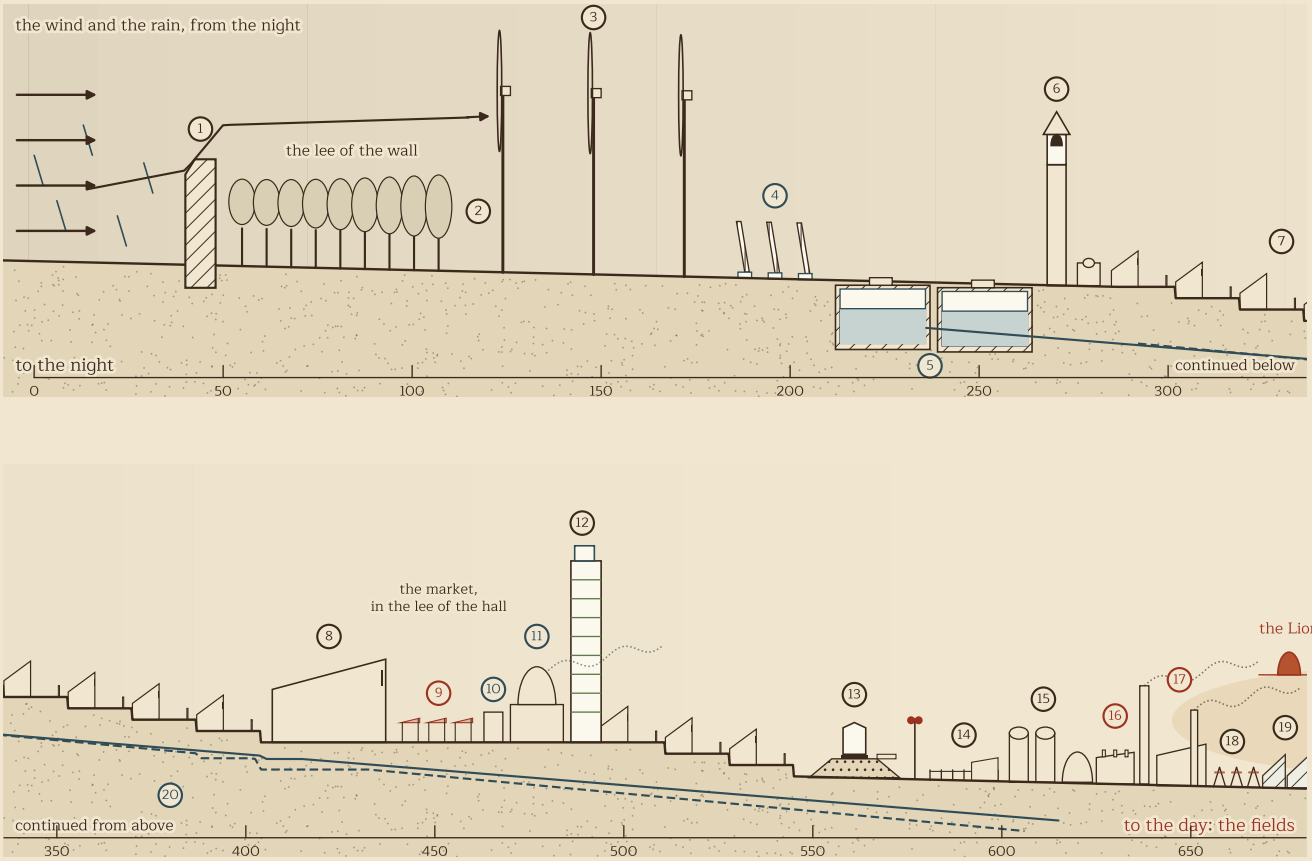
- A farming town of 12,000 at a curve of the river. Its council has a seat for the farmers, one for the merchants and one for the water.
- The grain grows in strips along the belt, each in the lee of a terrace wall; the stormroot belt shelters them all.
- Wind-grain does not grow below about 12 degrees. Cold air from the notch lies on the lowest terraces, where no wind takes it away.
- Two waters: the river waters the floor, through the settling basin; the scarp waters the slope, through the catch channel along the last terrace wall. What the river brings reaches only the floor.
- Every load for the house waits under the lean-to at the last terrace wall, with a slate beside it. Nothing goes up empty.

A companion to sheet 21 of the atlas. The relief, the river, the roads and the places come from the survey and its local sheet; the fields and the town are drawn over them. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 7

The Town across the Belt

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · a heartland town cut along a cross lane · lengths 1 : 2,000, heights 1 : 1,000



Meters from the open ground of the night. The section follows a cross lane: the wind and the light go down it together.

Dayward, with the wind

The wind and the rain. Smell: a person smells only what is nightward of them, so the town smells the ice and not itself. Sound: a bell is heard far down the wind and hardly at all up it. Smoke, dust and the used water.

Nightward, against the wind

The light, which comes level from the Lion, and the shadows, which point to the night. The sweet water comes from the night end, and so do the clean air and the cold.

1 The wall

The outer windbreak. Its windward face is carved, and at the height of a hand the carving is worn smooth.

2 The stormroot belt

Resin and damp bark. Stormroot is the only wood; a council releases it for beams and drums.

3 The turbines

They beat. Their power goes first to pumps, growing towers, rail and public works.

4 The condensers

They face the damp air as it arrives. Children scrape the scale from them every seven days.

5 The cisterns

Cold, wet stone. After a line of storm the gutters run into them, and people stop work to listen.

6 The bell house and the drum

At the nightward end, because sound goes dayward. The keeper rings by the clock.

7 The rows

Common houses in their compounds (plate 10). The town climbs in terraces, so each row sees over the next toward the day.

8 The hall

The meal, the stories and the announcements at the fourth bell. The rota board hangs here.

9 The market court

In the lee of the hall. It is open from the second bell to the third.

10 The water tally

Each household comes once a day. It is the surest place to find a person.

11 The steam house

On the thermal exchanger. A person goes once in a few days. News passes here.

12 The growing tower

Wet roots, green leaf and the pond smell of the feed water. Fresh leaf is the small luxury of a day.

13 The Whisper Road

It runs along the belt, so the section crosses it: a carriage seen end-on, and the Thread on its poles.

14 The goat pens

The first of the used end. Every town keeps goats, for hair, milk and a little meat.

15 The recyclers

They take what the latrines hold. Their gas feeds the collective kitchens and the kiln.

16 The drying house and the kiln

The dead are dried here, and their water goes back into the loop. Then the kiln burns them.

17 Forges and tanners

Hot metal and smoke. The smoke goes dayward, away from the town.

18 The drying yards

Racks of fish and hides. The smell of drying fish belongs to the dayward end.

19 The greenhouses

Glass high on the dayward side. They are at the day end because they need the light.

20 The hydroloop

Sweet water from the cisterns at the night end; used water to the works at the day end.

Brown: stone and earth. Blue: water. Red: fire and heat. Sizes are those of a town of the heartland, in the nightward half of the Central band; other towns differ in degree more than in kind. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 8

A Heartland Town

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the town of plate 07 in plan, with two quarters · 1 : 4,000

1 The wall

The outer windbreak, open at each cross lane. Its windward face is carved.

2 The stormroot belt

Resin and damp bark, in the lee of the wall.

3 The turbines

At the night end, where the wind arrives. Small turbines also stand in the cross lanes.

4 The condensers

They face the damp air as it arrives. Children scrape the scale from them every seven days.

5 The cisterns

Covered and deep, because open water is lost to the wind.

6 The bell house and the drum

At the nightward end of the town, on the main cross lane, because sound goes dayward.

7 The rows

Compounds of plate 10, five in each block. Each row stands on its own terrace and sees over the next toward the day.

8 The hall

The meal, the stories and the announcements at the fourth bell; the rota board.

9 The market court

In the lee of the hall, where the wind does not reach. Open from the second bell to the third.

10 The water tally

Each household of the quarter comes once a day for its measures.

11 The steam house

One in each quarter, on the thermal exchanger. News passes here.

12 The growing tower

Fresh leaf, the small luxury of an ordinary day.

13 The Whisper Road

Along the belt, on its embankment, with a halt, and the Thread on its poles beside it.

14 The goat pens

The first of the used end, downwind of every house.

15 The recyclers

What the latrines hold comes here. Their gas feeds the kitchens and the kiln.

16 The drying house and the kiln

At the dayward end of the town, on the main cross lane.

17 Forges and tanners

Hot metal and smoke, which the wind carries away from the town.

18 The drying yards

Racks of fish and hides on the lit side.

19 The greenhouses

At the day end, because they need the light.

20 The hydroloop

Sweet water from the cisterns, and used water back to the works, under the main cross lanes.

21 The council floor

The baraza of the town: forums and hearings, with the thing in dispute in the circle.

22 The lanes

Cross lanes run from the night to the day: bright and loud. Long lanes run along the belt: calm and dim, with the doors and the children.

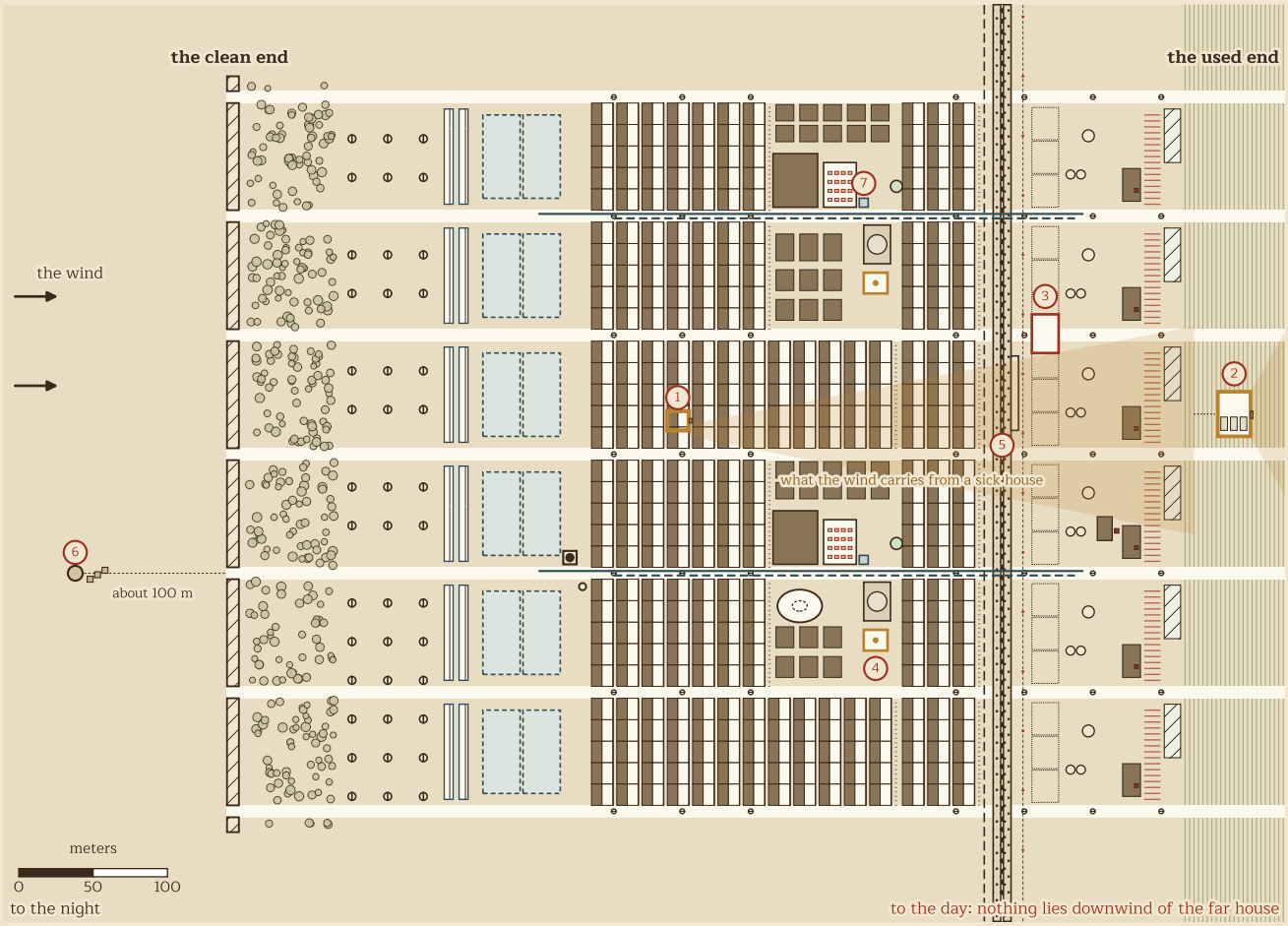
Brown: houses. Pale: courts. Blue: water and cisterns (dashed: under the ground). Red: fire, heat, stalls. Ticks: the edge of a terrace, down toward the day.
The section of plate 07 follows the cross lane A. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 9

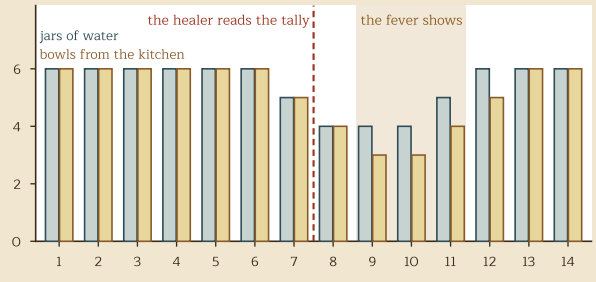
Sickness in the Town

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the wind carries it dayward, and the town is arranged by the wind

The heartland town of plate 08, and where sickness goes · 1 : 5,000

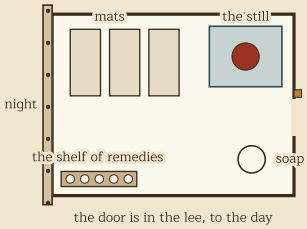


Counting as care

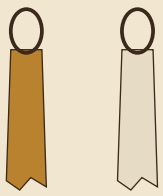


One house of six, drawn as an example. A house that draws less water, or takes fewer bowls from the common kitchen, often has a sick person in it. The tally sees sickness before the healer does.

A healing house · 1 : 250



Two cloths



A closed town

1. The healer gives the count.
2. The council decides in the open.
3. The gate is closed.
4. The warning goes down the relays and the wind songs; the Caravan Guilds carry it.
5. Neighbors leave loads at the drop stone, step back and wait.
6. Every day of a closed gate is counted.

Trade stops. Councils close late, and they are blamed either way. The debt of the drop stone is remembered on both sides.

1 A sick house

Ochre cloth on the ring of the door. Neighbors leave cooked food and sealed water on the step, knock twice and step back. The measure of the sick stays full.

2 The far house

At the dayward end, beyond the used end, downwind of every other house. A person with a catching sickness lies here.

3 The guest house

By the halt. The three days of a guest are also a watch; if a guest has fever, the guest house becomes a sick house.

4 The healing house

One in each quarter, near the steam house: mats, a still, a pot of soap, the shelf of remedies.

5 The palm

Where the town has a thermal sensor at the gate, each traveler gives a palm on arrival.

6 The drop stone

Outside the wall, upwind, for a closed town.

7 The water tally

The healer reads it every day.

Ochre: sickness and what the wind carries from it. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Buildings

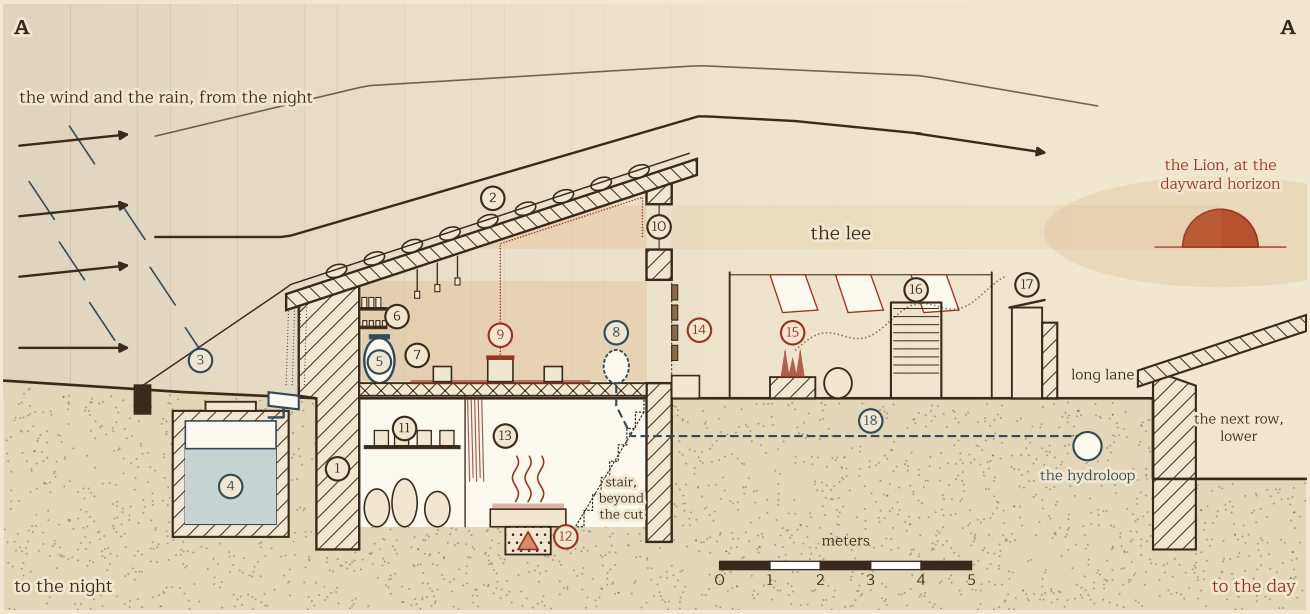
Each building is drawn in a cut, so that you can follow the air, the heat and the water through it. Look at where the warmth comes from and where each drop goes: nothing is thrown away, and every room is placed along that path. The storm haven and the Deep Road gate are the buildings a town depends on in danger and in trade.

Plate 10 The Common House
Plate 11 The Steam House
Plate 12 A Growing Tower
Plate 13 Bantay-Hanga
Plate 14 The Water Judge's Chamber
Plate 15 A Storm Haven
Plate 16 A Deep Road Gate

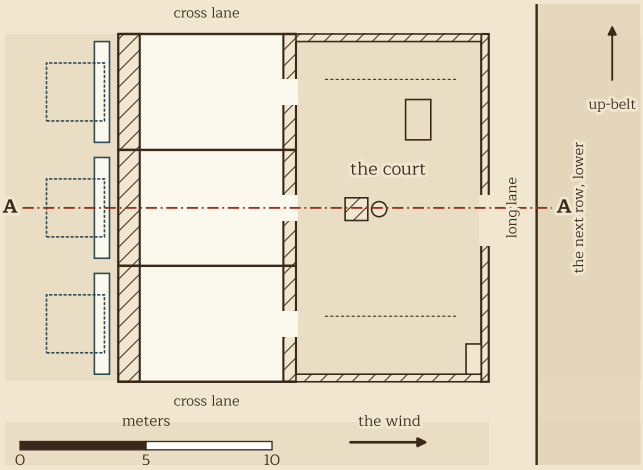
Plate 10

The Common House

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · a house of the heartland, cut across the belt at A · 1 : 150



The compound, from above · 1 : 300



Where the water goes

1. Rain: the back wall and the roof, the gutter, the cistern.
2. The measure: from the water tally of the quarter to the sweet jar.
3. Down the stair of uses: drinking and cooking, hands, the body, cloth, the floor and the plants.
4. The used jar, then the hydroloop or the plants.

Where the heat comes from

- The hearth in the court, on fuel cake.
- The hot plate, on the power quota.
- The heat stone below, for a phase at a time.
- The ground round the lower rooms, which holds an even warmth.
- Not in the house: the steam house of the quarter, on the thermal exchanger.

1 The back

The nightward wall: thick, low, with no opening. Its footing goes below the lower rooms. Cold stays in it.

2 The roof

Low at the back, high at the face. Rows of stones and a net of cable, staked to the ground, hold it down. It hums.

3 The gutter

At the foot of the back wall. The wind drives the rain on the wall and down the roof into it.

4 The cistern

Under a stone lid, at the foot of the back wall. After a line of storm it fills, and people stop to listen.

5 The sweet jar

Sealed. It stands against the back wall, where it is cool. It holds the measures of the house.

6 Cups and tablets

The shelf of the cups of the family, each one different, and above it the names of the dead.

7 Mats and stools

Wrap cloths hang as curtains. Tools hang on pegs, each one carved.

8 The used jar

It takes the water that has served once. It goes to the hydroloop or to the plants, never on the ground.

9 The hot plate

It runs on the power quota of the house. The line comes in under the roof.

10 The face

The dayward wall: the door and the high window. The level light of the Lion comes in under the roof.

11 The store

At the back, in the cold of the wall: crocks, sacks, the porridge stock.

12 The heat stone

A geothermal crystal in a lined bin under the sleeping room. It gives back its heat for a whole phase.

13 The sleeping room

Below, where the ground keeps the warmth. A wrap cloth closes it from the store.

14 Bench and cake

The bench of the face. Above it the fuel cake (kuni) dries on the lit wall.

15 The hearth

The jiko, in the lee. It burns cake, slow and sour. The smoke goes dayward with the wind.

16 Loom and lines

The loom of the court, and the drying lines: cloth is aired in the wind more than it is washed.

17 The latrine

Dry, with two jars and a scoop of ash, at the dayward side of the court, downwind. The solid jar goes to the recyclers.

18 The hydroloop

The line of used water under the long lane, back to the works of the quarter.

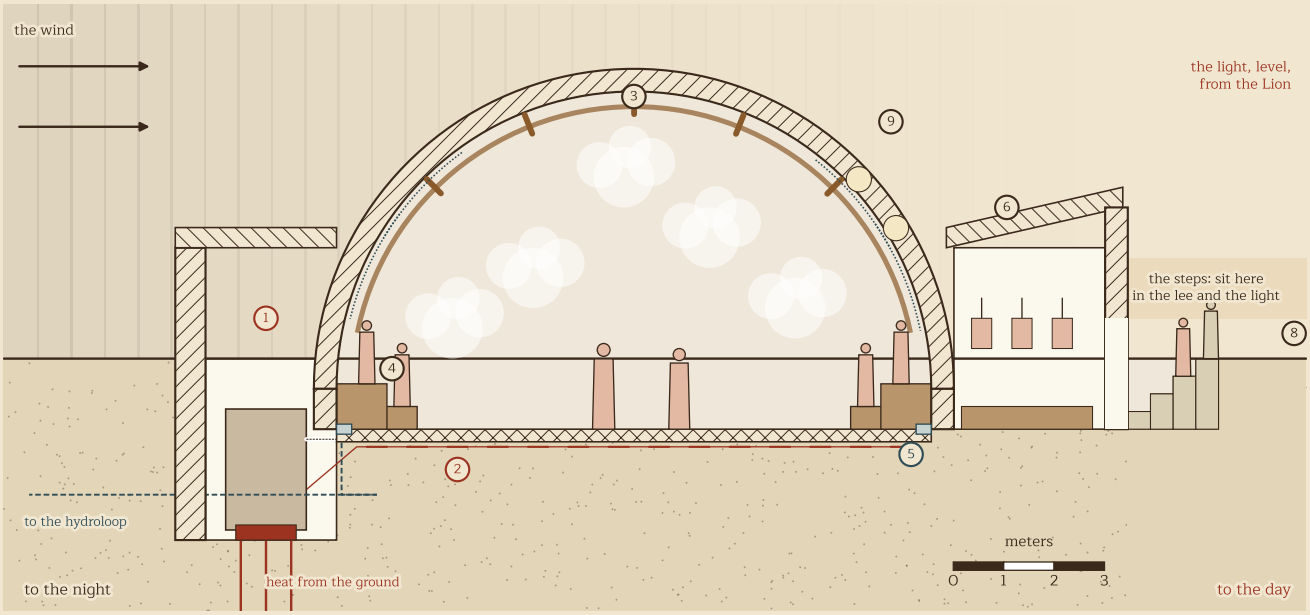
Brown: stone and earth, cut where hatched. Blue: water. Red: heat and fire. Sizes are those of a common house; rich houses and city blocks change them, but they keep the order. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate II

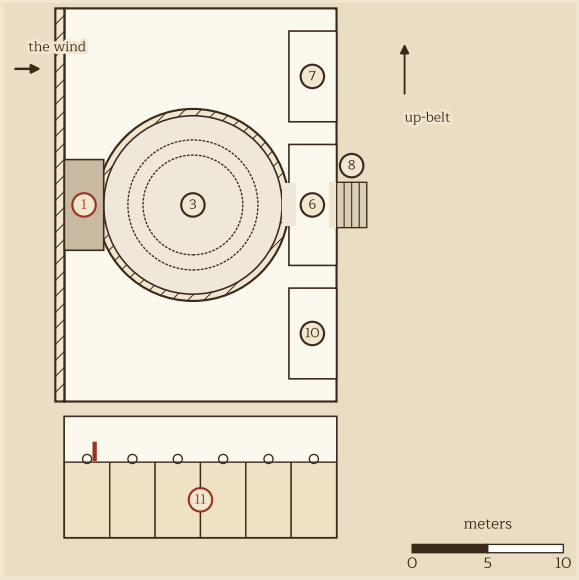
The Steam House

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the hamamu of a heartland quarter, as in plate 08

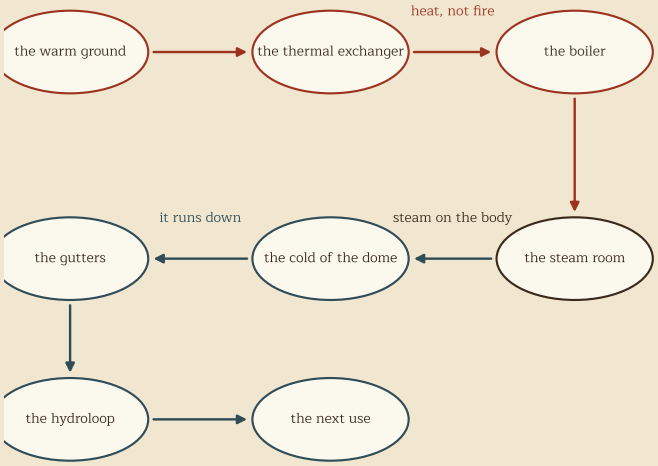
The steam house across the belt · 1 : 150



In plan · 1 : 500



Heat and water



Much heat is not fire: the thermal exchangers draw on the warmth of the ground. In the north and in the caves steam costs nothing, and the Fire Land has baths.

1 The exchanger room

Against the back wall, sunk into the ground. The thermal exchanger heats the boiler with the warmth of the ground.

2 The warm floor

Heat runs under the stone floor of the steam room.

3 The steam room

A dome sunk a little below the lane, with benches in tiers round its wall. Its beams are stormroot: warm in the steam, they give off resin.

4 The back wall

Thick, low, nightward, with no opening, like the back of every house.

5 The gutters

Steam turns to water on the cold dome and runs down to gutters at its foot, and back to the hydroloop.

6 The undressing room

On the dayward side: pegs, cloth, a bench.

7 The oil room

Oil and a scraper take off what the steam has loosened.

8 The steps

On the lit face, in the lee. A place to sit after the steam, and a place where people court.

9 The openings

Small and high on the dayward side of the dome: the light is low inside.

10 The cool room

Where people sit before they go out into the wind.

11 The quiet rooms

Beside the steam house, for people who have no privacy at home. Nobody pays and nobody gives a name. A cloth on the ring shows that a room is in use.

In the life of the quarter

- A heartland town has a steam house in each quarter. A person goes once in a few days.
- It is the place where news passes. "Heard" news from the steam house is repeated as heard.
- A person who has come from the steam house smells of resin, from the stormroot beams warm in the steam.
- People joke there, without malice and without names.
- A pot of soap stands in each steam house. The recycler crew comes here at the end of its turn.
- The healing house of the quarter stands near the steam house.
- Among the things that people love: the steam house. Among the things that they fear: to be lost in mist, a cave, a closed room.

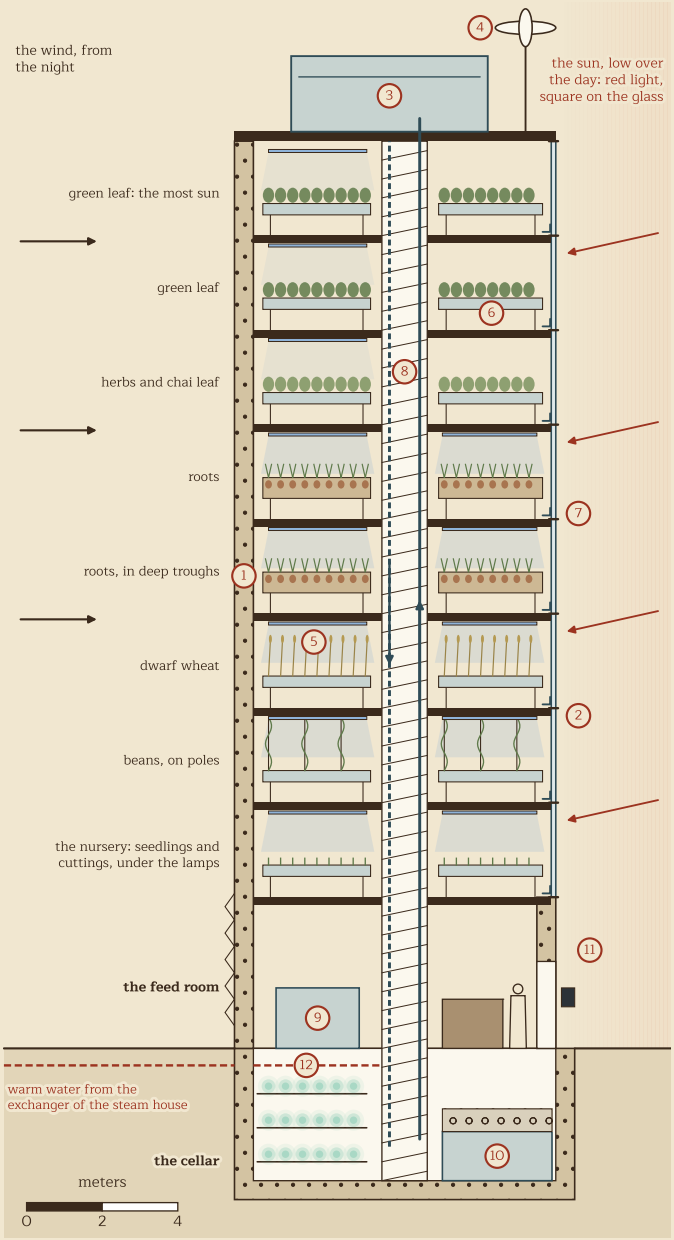
The footprint is the one of plate 08 (about 18 by 26 m). Brown: stone and earth. Blue: water. Red: heat.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 12

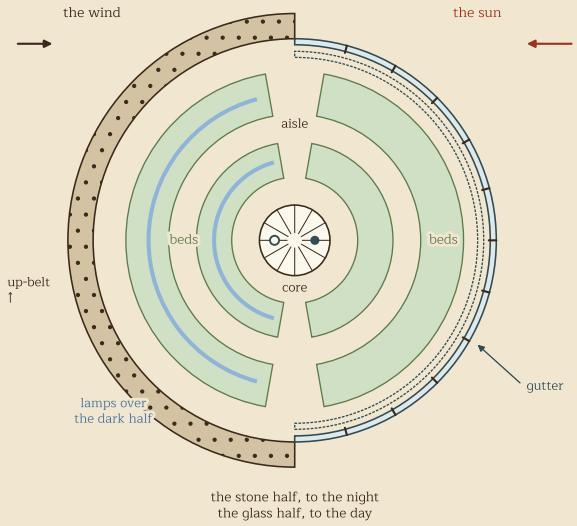
A Growing Tower

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the shamba-juu of a heartland quarter, as in plate 08

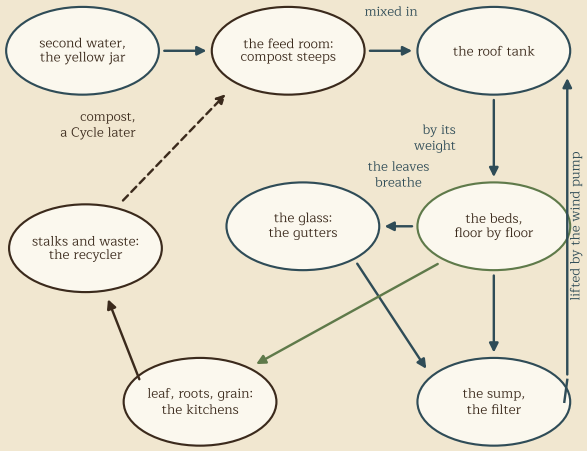
Section across the belt · 1 : 200



A growing floor · 1 : 150



Water, food and compost



Water that enters the tower leaves it as leaf or not at all: what the leaves breathe out wets the glass and runs back to the sump.

1 The nightward wall

Stone, thick, with no opening: it takes the wind, like the back of every house. A band of carving at its foot: grain, water, the balance.

2 The glass face

The dayward half, in panels. It takes the low red sun square on, where a field takes it at a slant.

3 The roof tank

Feed water. From it the water runs down through the beds by its own weight.

4 The wind pump

On the roof. It lifts the water from the sump to the tank.

5 The lamps

Blue-white, under each floor, over the dark half and the lower floors. They give what the red sun lacks.

6 The beds

Troughs in rings round the core. The water runs through them and down to the floor below.

7 The gutters

At the foot of the glass on each floor. They take the water that runs down the glass.

8 The core

A stair round a column, the feed pipe going up and the drain coming down.

9 The feed room

Second water and the water of the yellow jar come in here. Compost steeps in a vat: it gives the pond smell.

10 The cellar

Shelves of glowcaps in the dark, the sump and its gravel filter.

11 The door

In the lee, with a tally slate: every crate of leaf that goes out is counted.

12 The warm pipe

Water from the exchanger of the steam house keeps the cellar and the core warm.

In the life of the quarter

- Each quarter has a growing tower beside its steam house. The quarter works it.
- The growers go in at the first bell, before the rest of the quarter is at work.
- Inside: wet roots, green leaf, the pond smell of the feed water. The air is warm and wet, and the glass runs.
- Fresh green leaf is the small luxury of an ordinary day. It goes out by the tally of the quarter.
- Power from the wind banks goes first to pumps, growing towers, rail and public works.
- The glass face shows the cold blue of the lamps, a light seen nowhere else in a town.
- To foul a growing tower makes a person tangazali, land-poisoner. The first penalty is the work of cleaning, for as long as the cleaning takes.

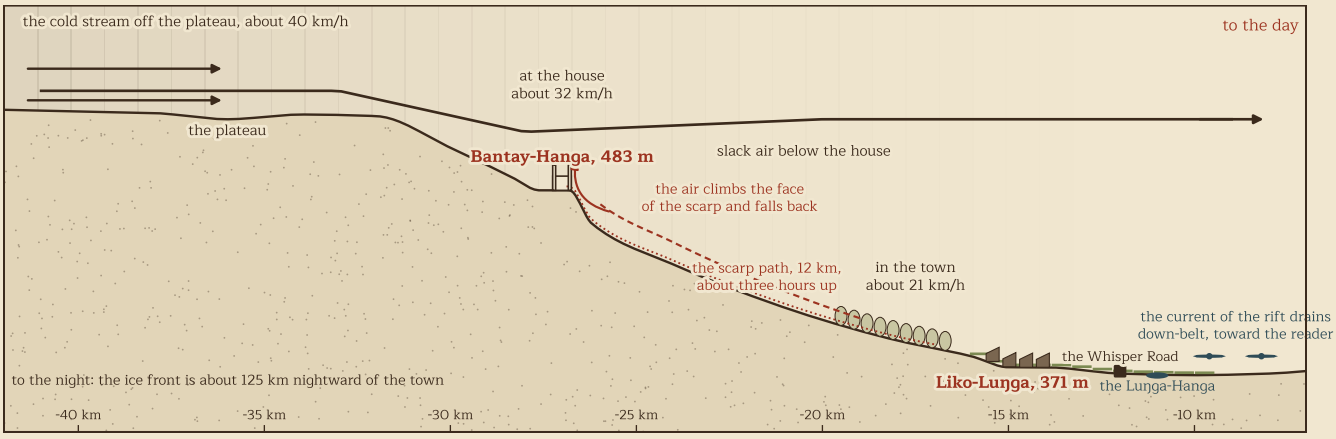
The tower is the one of plates 07 and 08: about 8 m across and 24 m high, with its tank on the roof. Brown: stone and earth. Blue: water. Red: heat and the sun.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 13

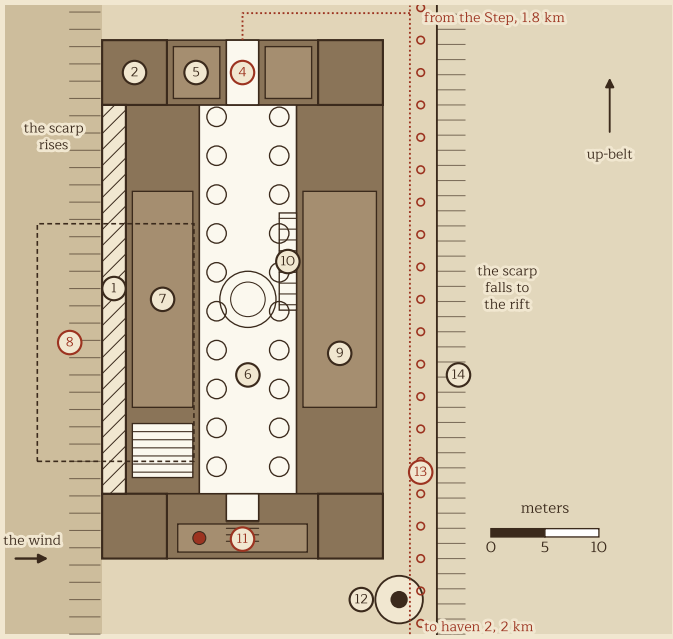
Bantay-Hanga

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the Wind Watch, guild house of Liko-Luŋga, alama 2,852, offset -27

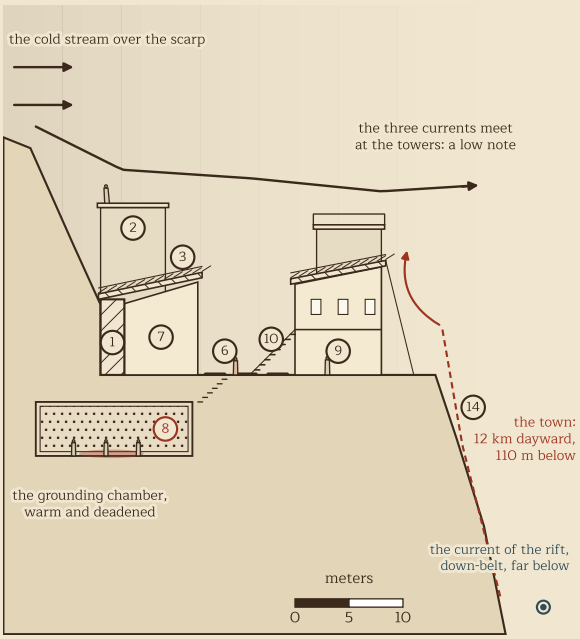
The scarp at the house · across the belt at alama 2,852 · heights about 45 times the lengths



The house in plan · 1 : 700



The house across the belt · 1 : 700



1 The back wall

A long low wall of grey rock, with its back to the night side, close against the scarp that rises behind it.

2 The towers

One at each corner. In a working the ring stands on them. The nightward tower has no rail at the edge of its platform.

3 The roofs

Held down under nets of cable, as on every house of the belt.

4 The gate

At the up-belt end, where the shelf path comes in. Inside it the wind drops. The cook counts each load at the door.

5 The archive

The records of the house.

6 The court

Paved, and ringed with circles cut in the stone.

7 The Listening Hall

Along the back wall. The lead of a working holds the picture here.

8 The grounding chamber

Under the ground, warmed by the rock and deadened to sound: a refuge from the constant sense, and the place of the Held in a working.

9 The hall

The meal at the fourth bell.

10 The dayward stair

Up to the rooms of the Newly Called.

11 The far arch

Through it and down the steps to the kitchen. Smoke leaves a vent and goes flat at once.

12 Storm haven 1

A hema-tufani. The first of seven on the shelf, about 2 km apart, down-belt from the house.

13 The shelf path

With the storm line on iron rings, a ring every few paces.

14 The shelf and the scarp

The house stands on the shelf where the lee of the scarp ends, 110 m above the town.

The climb

1. The path leaves the town at the last terrace wall, where the stormroot belt ends.
2. One hour of long legs, then short ones on bare rock. Iron rings at each turn hold the storm line; a person clips on when the house says so.
3. The Step, two hours from the town: the path comes out from behind a shoulder of the scarp, and the lee ends. Everyone falls at the Step the first time.
4. Most of an hour level along the shelf, with a ring every few paces, to the gate.

· Nothing goes up empty: each person who climbs carries part of the supplies of the house.

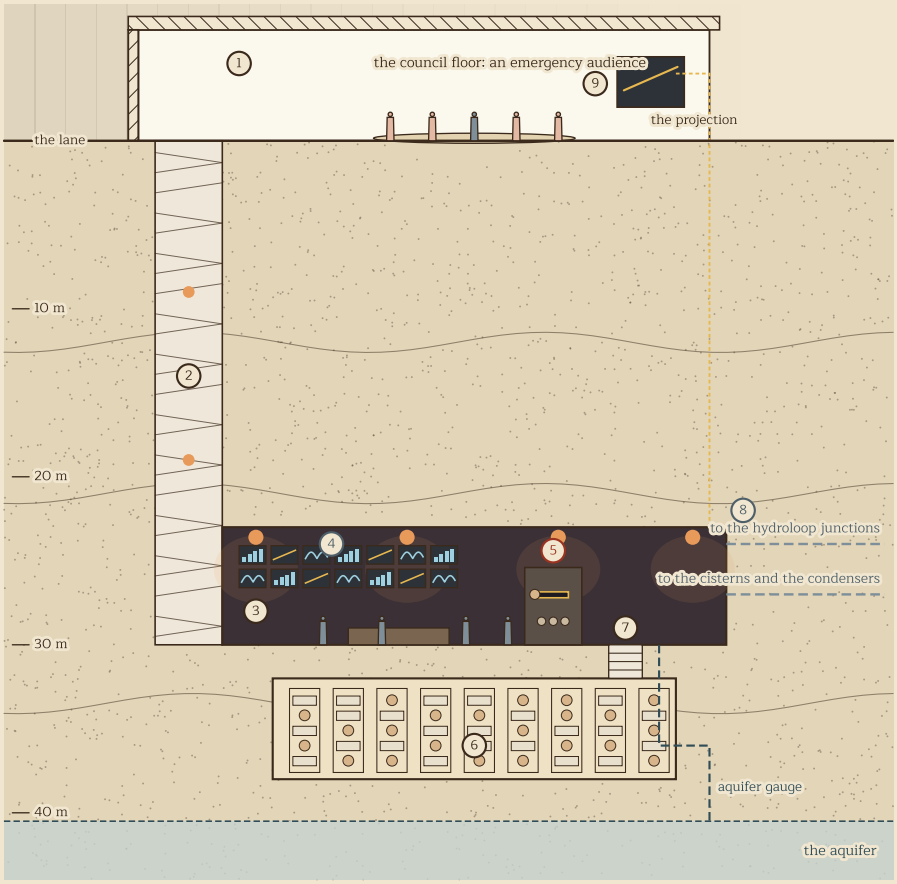
About twenty practitioners live here, with the Held, the Newly Called and the people who keep the house.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 14

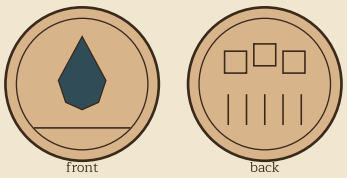
The Water Judge's Chamber

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the monitoring chamber of a major settlement, under its council floor

Under the council floor · 1 : 450



A water token



Fired and glazed ceramic, marked with the glyphs of the settlement; a water drop marks a thing of water. It stands for a right to water, it is linked to a role and a person, and it is needed to override a valve. Tokens pass down families and change hands in alliances. To withhold one is power.

The judge

Hakimu-maji. The blue-gray robe looks like slate out of doors.
Training: data, tokens, crises.

- Allocation and conservation of water: the judge measures a loss from the tally and the flow records.
- Token authentication, by the psychic signature of the token.
- In a crisis: emergency rationing, and the damage to the water works.
- At a gate: a judge tests each load of ice before it goes on, and reads the tokens that come with it.
- Like anyone, a judge takes turns on the cistern crew and carries the latrine jars to the recyclers.
- The water judges continue the councils of elders that divided irrigation water between the farms.

1 The council floor

The baraza. In an emergency audience the judges bring their data up to it and show it on the projection.

2 The stair

Down about 30 meters to the chamber.

3 The monitoring chamber

Lit by geothermal fixtures. Most of the system runs by itself; the judges watch it.

4 The tablet banks

Hydroloop junction flows, aquifer depths, condenser outputs, in real time.

5 The valve station

Critical valves and manual overrides open only with an authorized water token in the slot.

6 The archive

Generations of water rights: ceramic tokens, trade manifests, quota changes. Only judges and authorized delegates enter.

7 The way down

From the chamber to the archive.

8 The sensor lines

Out to the junctions, the cisterns, the condensers and the gauges of the aquifer.

9 The projection

Crisis data on several screens, for a council that must decide fast.

Before the council

Four faults have a name that nobody wants to carry. The council hears each case in the open; the specialist gives the measurements.

majimaka	water-killer	to lose water through carelessness, or take it out of the loop
hangaboru	wind-blocker	to take wind from the common turbines or a neighbor
tangazali	land-poisoner	to foul soil, a growing tower or an aquifer
kinabara	hoarder	to hold more than the quota; the lightest and the most common

The scale of penalties, one step at a time

1. Return: give back what was lost.
2. Extra turns on the rota, in public.
3. A smaller ration; the children keep theirs.
4. Loss of office: a water token, a grade or a seat.
5. Expulsion, always for a term, to a place that agrees to receive the person.

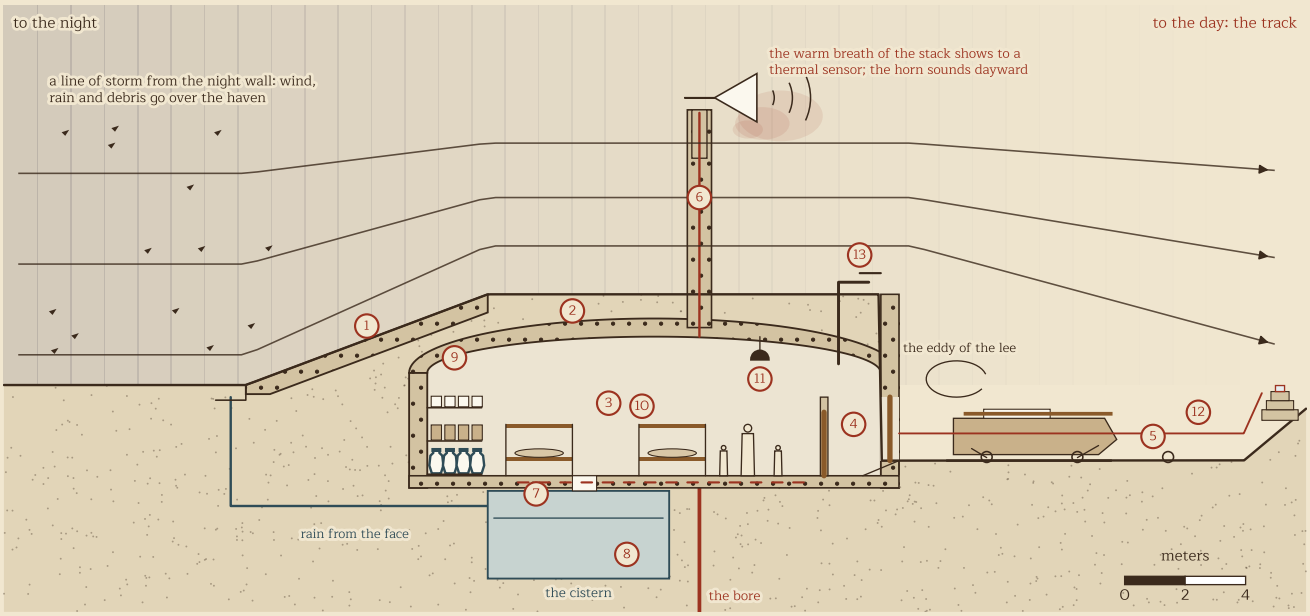
The depth is the usual one ("typically 30 meters deep"); the layout is that of a major settlement.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 15

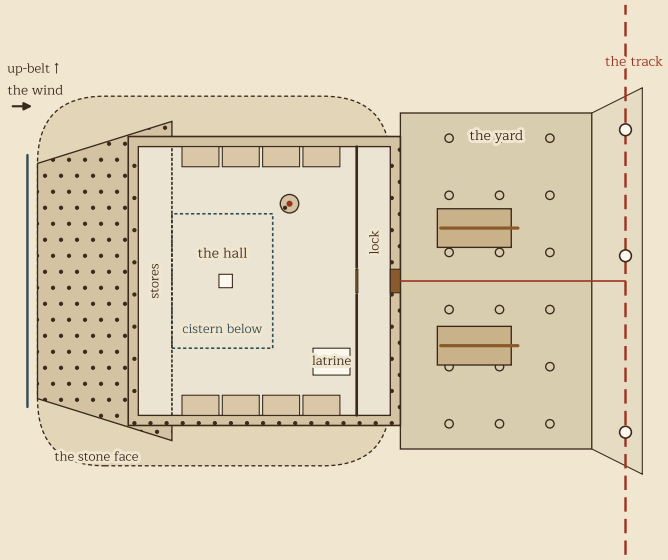
A Storm Haven

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · a hema-tufani on a caravan track of the open ground

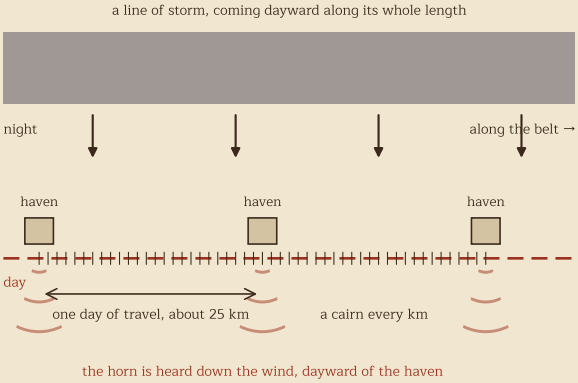
Section across the belt · 1 : 250



Plan · 1 : 450



On the track



A caravan halts at a haven at the end of each day of travel, so it is never more than half a day from one. Before a storm the air tastes of copper.

1 The face

Stone, sloped to the night. The wind and what it carries go over the haven. The face takes the rain, and a gutter at its foot leads it to the cistern.

2 The cover

Earth over the vault, as deep as a person is tall.

3 The vault

One long room in the ground, of stone, for one caravan.

4 The lock

Two doors, never open together. They keep out the dust and hold against the pressure shifts.

5 The yard

Sunk in the lee. The sleds lower their masts and are tied to iron rings.

6 The beacon

A stack over the bore. Its warm breath shows to a thermal sensor through a storm; the wind horn on its top sounds while the wind blows.

7 The warm floor

Heat from the same bore.

8 The cistern

Rain from the face. Its hatch is in the floor of the hall.

9 The stores

Sealed water jars, flour, dried food, lamp oil, cake, cord, cloth, tethers, medicine; the flares in a stone box apart.

10 The bunks

Two tiers along the walls. In a storm a caravan sleeps in turns.

11 The bell

In the dark of a storm someone rings the bells and keeps the count.

12 The storm line

From the track to the door, on iron rings, with a cairn at the turn.

13 The vent

On the lee side, under a hood.

The custom of the haven

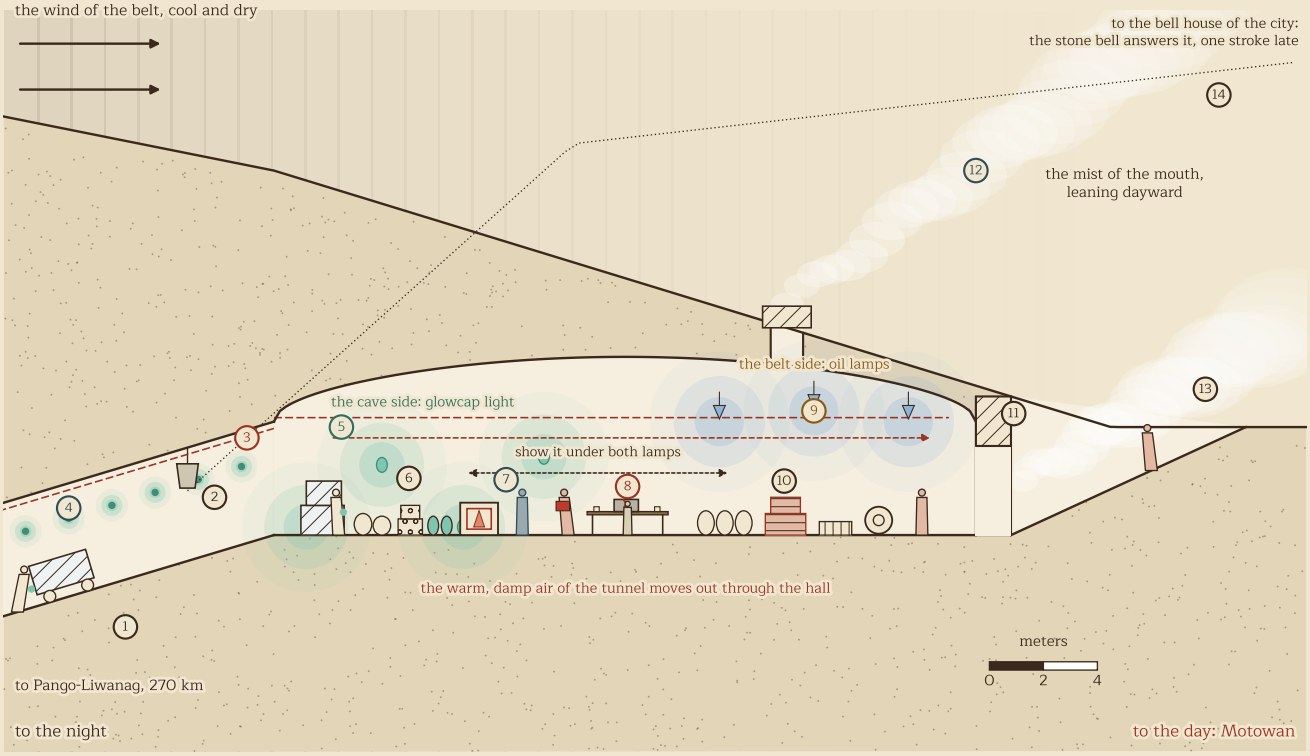
- Nobody is turned away from a haven. A quarrel waits at the door.
- Take what you need, leave what you can, and write both on the slate of the haven.
- A caravan that crosses a storm wall carries stores to restock the havens on its way.
- The first in makes chai for those who come after.
- The seals of the water jars are counted. A jar is opened only in a storm.
- The Caravan Guilds keep the havens. After a great storm the nearest town sends a team to check them, and to look for the people whom the storm did not give back.

A haven of the heartland, on open ground between two cities. Brown: stone and earth. Blue: water. Red: heat, the track and the line.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 16

A Deep Road Gate

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · a gate hall on a trade day, as at Motowan, cut across the belt · 1 : 280



Show it under both lamps

under the glowcaps

under the oil lamp

The same three cloths: red, ochre and blue. A buyer carries cloth or dye across the hall before anybody says a price. "Show it under both lamps" is also what people say when they doubt a story.

A trade day

- Each side gives the cup to the other before trade begins.
- The Deepkin speak low and slowly, and the Belters are too loud for them. Much of the trade is by hand sign; the Deepkin add the glowing marks on their fingers.
- A deal closes on nzuri.
- The Deepkin receive a guest with care and trust late: a trader who has come to the same gate for twenty Cycles still hears the same polite questions.
- Each side finds the other a little rude and does not say so.

1 The Deep Road

Dug by the Deepkin, one generation after another, and never finished. This one runs 270 km to Pango-Liwanag.

2 The stone bell

Both sides keep the same ten bells. The stone bell carries signals in the tunnel.

3 The Thread

Its wire comes down the largest Deep Roads to the largest Deepkin cities. It carries text only.

4 Ice in straw

Night-side ice, packed in straw against the warm air of the tunnel. The ice quota is one of the disputes of the gates.

5 The cave side

Glowcap jars, because the red light of the belt is hard on eyes made for the dark.

6 What comes up

Ice in straw, minerals, dried fungi and blind fish, glowing dyes, geothermal crystals in double crates.

7 The water judge

A water judge tests each load of ice before it goes on, and reads the tokens that come with it.

8 The envoy's table

A Wind and Flame Envoy sits between the sides. On the table lies the thing in dispute: here a cracked core.

9 The belt side

Oil lamps. A color is not the same under each lamp, so cloth crosses the hall before a price is said.

10 What goes down

Grain, cloth, tools and forged parts. The caves buy parts that only the surface cities make.

11 The mouth

The warm, damp air of the tunnel meets the cool, dry wind of the belt. Where they meet there is mist.

12 The plume

From far off, the mouth of a Deep Road is a white plume that leans dayward.

13 The ramp

Up to the yard and the city, where the caravans load. A caravan gives three rising notes on the flute when it arrives.

14 The bell

The sound goes dayward to the bell house of the city, and the stone bell answers it, one stroke late.

On the envoy's table: one of the eleven cracked cores of the thermal harvesters of Pango-Liwanag (the dispute of the cores of Motowan).
Brown: stone and earth. Blue: water and ice. Red: heat. Green and yellow: the two lights. A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Daily Life

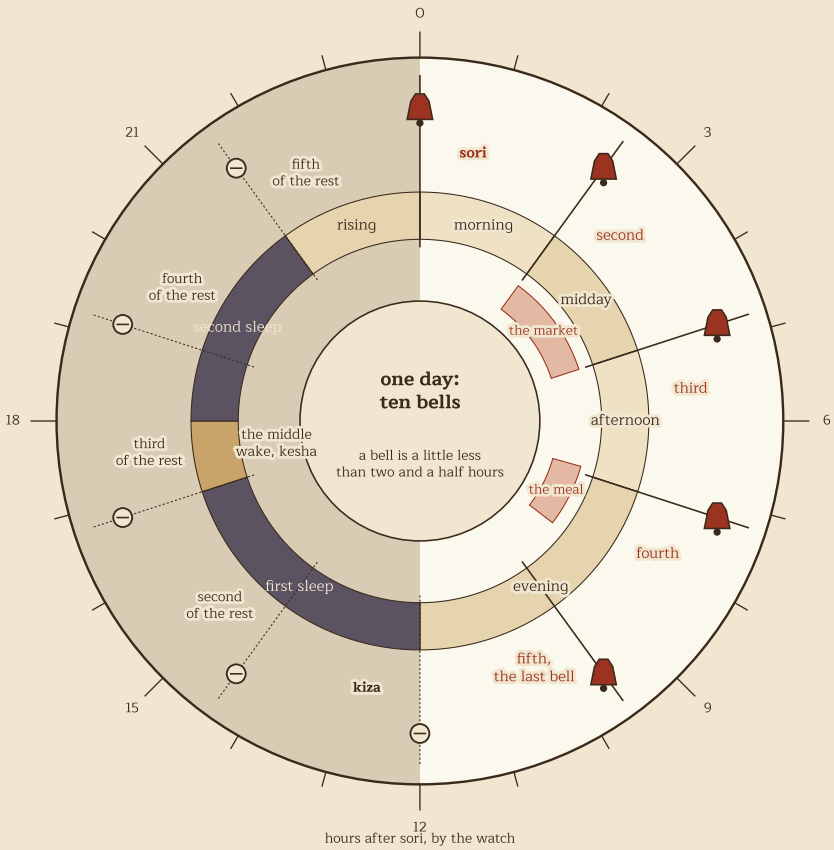
These plates show the rules that everyone knows and nobody needs to write down: the ten bells of a shared day, the rites of a life counted in Cycles, the path of water through a house, and the signs that the kin cut on doors and cups.

Plate 17 The Ten Bells
Plate 18 A Life in Cycles
Plate 19 Water in the Hand
Plate 20 The Marks of the Kin

Plate 17

The Ten Bells

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the shared day of a town, from sori to sori



What each bell marks

hours

the waking period: five loud bells; many stop for one breath and one word of thanks

sori 0

Work begins. It is not the bell of waking: people are up before it.

second 2.5

Markets open. Lessons begin.

third 5

The middle of the work. Shifts change.

fourth 7

The meal.

fifth, the last 9.5

The public day ends. Halls close and children go down. In the Cycle of saumu, people eat after it.

the rest period: five soft bells, one stroke each, for the watch

kiza 12

First sleep.

second of the rest 14.5

third of the rest 17

The middle wake.

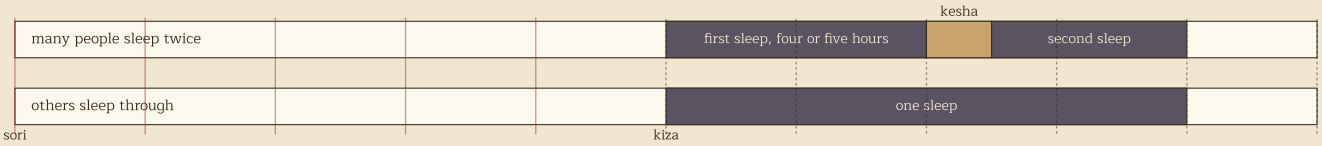
fourth of the rest 19

Second sleep.

fifth of the rest 21.5

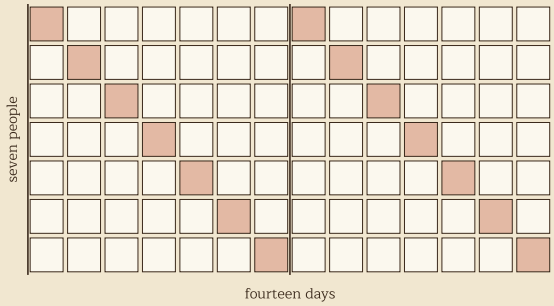
Rising: the cloth and the cup, thin porridge, chai, the walk to work.

Two ways to sleep



A town never sleeps all at once: the watch and the rest shift keep the works. Nobody remarks on either habit. Darkness is made: the sleeping room is the lowest and darkest room of the house.

One day in seven



By old custom a person rests one day in seven, as the caravans do. The rota sets the day for each person, so a town never stops all at once. The span of seven days has no name.

Longer time

- A day is ten bells, near enough a day of Earth. A Cycle has not quite thirty-five of them.
- No part of the Cycle is warm and none is cold. The weather has phases.
- People date their lives by storms, the heading of the grain, festivals and births. The count of Cycles is for contracts.

The bell house.

It keeps a clock, and its keeper rings by it. It stands at the nightward end of a town, because sound goes dayward.

Watches.

Many people carry one. A watch tells one person the hour; a bell tells everybody at once.

Under the night.

The caves keep the same count of ten bells, by stone bell and chime, because trade needs one count.

Out of bell.

A person whose sleep has left the bells is in some trouble: grief, sickness, or a new ability. Alone, with no bell, the body makes a longer day: a lone traveler comes into a town a bell late.

Where it comes from.

The prayer calls of the settlers and the watch bells of the ship became one custom. The soft bells of the rest came from the ship.

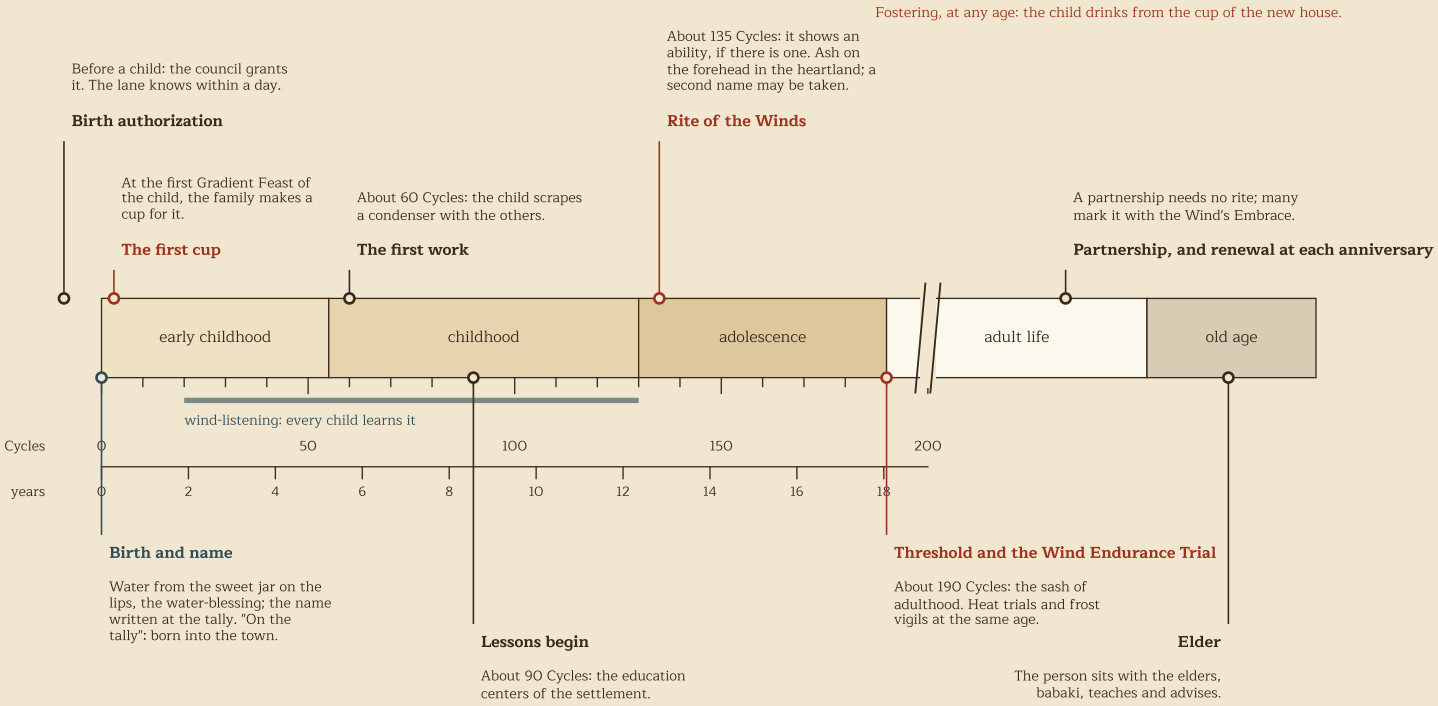
The hours are those of a watch; the times of the bells are rounded.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 18

A Life in Cycles

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the rites of a Belter life, from the birth authorization to the name set free

The rites of a life · childhood at full scale; adult life and old age shortened



By about ninety Cycles, a child can

- tie down a load so that it stays;
- pour without loss;
- read the nightward sky for a line that is coming;
- make the hand signals and speak the storm register;
- find the nearest storm haven from any place in the town;
- say the survival poems of the house;
- keep a tally.

Ages

A child's age is given in Cycles and an adult's in years. The count of Cycles is for contracts and records; people date their own lives by storms, the heading of the grain, festivals and births.

55 Cycles	about 5 years	early childhood ends
90 Cycles	about 9 years	lessons begin
135 Cycles	about 13 years	the Rite of the Winds
190 Cycles	about 18 years	the Threshold

The dead

The body is dried, so that its water returns to the settlement, and then it is burned.

1 The vigil
One rest period in the lower room of the house. The kin oil the body; they use no water. The door stands open, and anyone may come down.

→

2 The drying
At the drying house, at the dayward end of the town. The water goes back into the loop: the dead "has given back the water". The name is struck from the tally.

→

3 The burning
A kiln, on recycler gas; in the Fire Land, the heat of a vent.

→

4 The ash
Carried to a place where three currents meet. The kin face the wind, speak the name and open the hand. The ash goes dayward.

→

5 The tablet
Houses that keep name tablets add one.

→

6 The name
Nobody in the close family carried it while the person lived. Now it is free for the next child.

Mourning.

An undyed cloth on the ring of the door for one Cycle. No hearth for seven days; the neighbors bring cooked food. A parent who loses a child has leave from the rota.

Taken by a storm.

If a storm took a person and did not give them back, the kin speak the name and open an empty hand.

The Deepkin.

They have no wind. They burn their dead at a vent, and the Bone Lorekeepers keep one small piece of bone from each in the wall of the Hearth, and say the names.

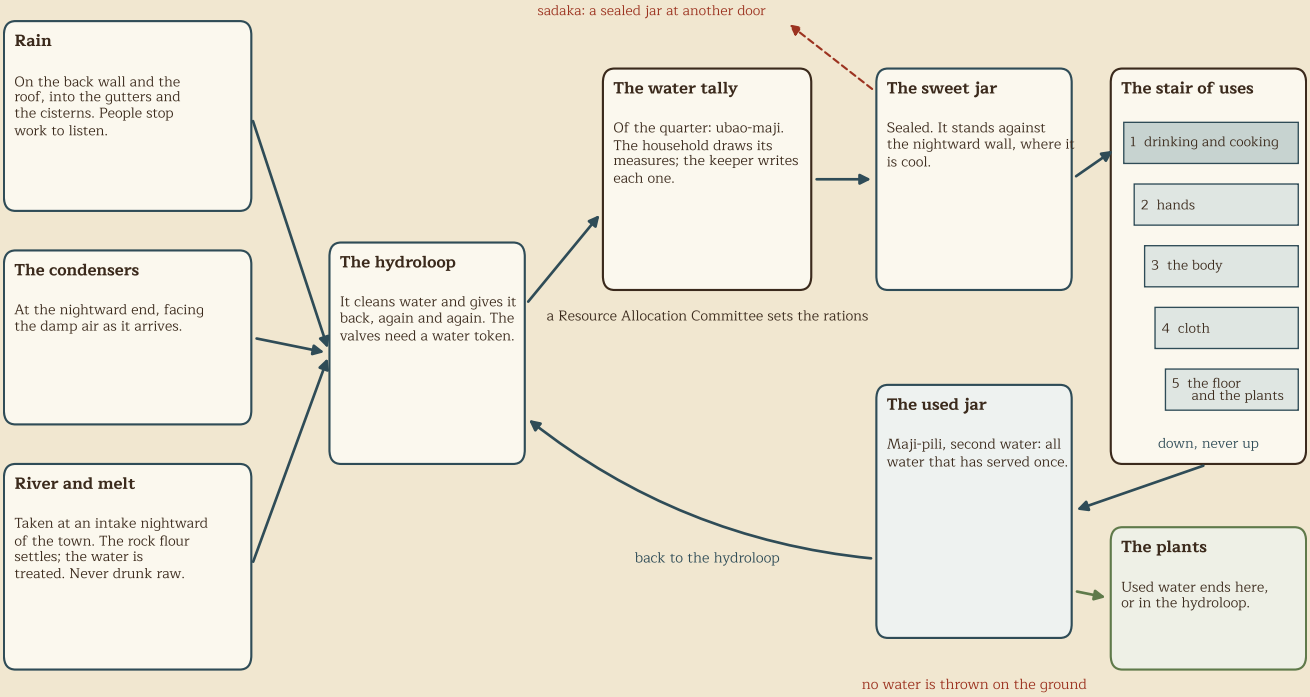
A Cycle is about 34.7 days, and years are the Archivists' count.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 19

Water in the Hand

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · how a heartland house catches, measures, uses and gives back its water

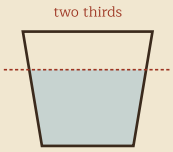
The way of the water: caught, cleaned, measured, used, given back



The measure, kibaba

Each person has a measure of sweet water for one day: in the heartland one jar, which a child of a hundred Cycles can carry. It is smaller in the Dry Land and larger in the Ice Land. A house has two jars: the sweet jar, sealed, and the used jar. The jars are not drawn to one scale.

Drinking and pouring



The cup is small. A host fills it to two thirds, because a full cup spills.

To spill is a fault; to spill and not see it is a worse one. The room is quiet for one breath, and nobody jokes until the person who spilled does.

People drink little plain water: thin porridge, chai and light grain ferment.

The first test of a small child is to carry a full cup across the court in the wind.

Washing

Hands.

One person pours from a small jug over the hands of another, above a basin, for about three breaths. The basin goes to the used jar. Before every meal; the youngest at the table pours.

The body.

A cloth and one cup, each day. Oil and a scraper take off the dust.

Teeth.

A chewing stick, mswaki. No water.

Soap.

Sabuni: soft, brown, smelling of smoke, of goat tallow and the lye of kuni ash. It needs rinse water, so it is used where dirt can kill: the healer, the birth room, the recycler crew, the cook after meat.

Pots and bowls.

Scoured dry with hearth ash and fine sand, then wiped; a little second water finishes the work.

The steam house.

One in each quarter, on the thermal exchanger. A person goes once in a few days. In the north and in the caves steam costs nothing.

Hair.

Braided close to the head or wrapped in a scarf: it keeps the dust out. Braiding is done in the court, in the lee, with hours of talk.

Clothes.

Beaten, aired in the wind and hung on the lit wall. Seldom washed; wool almost never.

The latrine.

Dry, with two jars and a scoop of ash. The yellow jar, with second water, goes to the plants: the last step of the stair. The other goes to the recyclers, whose water comes back through the stills.

The Deepkin.

Steam and warm water cost them nothing, and they wash every day.

The sound of water.

People know the sound of their pipes, and a drip wakes a sleeper. Anyone may knock on any door, at any bell, to report a joint that drips.

Sadaka.

A gift of water with no witness. A sealed jar stands at a door when the house wakes. Nobody asks who put it there.

The old jar.

Many who remember the embargo of the Thirst Wars keep one sealed jar more than their measure. By the letter of the law this is hoarding, kinabara. Their families know and do not speak of it.

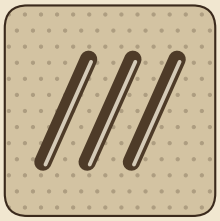
Water is the most precious thing, and waste is the worst fault. The rivers pass through and the wind takes what stands open.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Plate 20

The Marks of the Kin

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · the house, the line, the Wind-Kin, and the five signs

The five signs

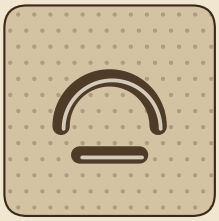


kin-Hanga

the Wind clan

Three strokes that lean the same way: grass in the wind.

Founding trade: the weather and the sails.



kin-Moto

the Fire clan

An arc over a short bar: the hearth.

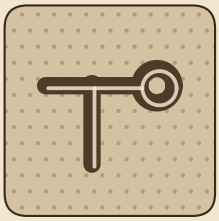
Founding trade: thermal work; the first ventures toward the day side.

kin-Maji

the Water clan

Three steps going down, a dot on the top one: the stair of uses.

Founding trade: the first cisterns; the water judges.

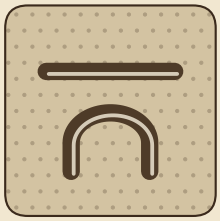


kin-Babu

the Elder clan

A cord with a knot and a loop: the knotted cord of the tally.

Founding trade: the keepers of the first records.



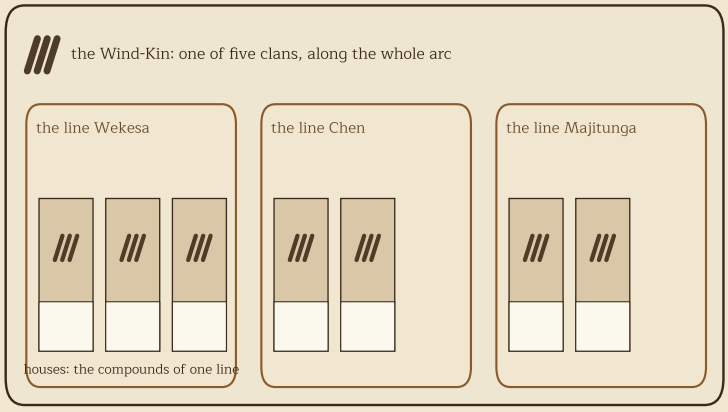
kin-Kivuli

the Shadow clan

An arch under a ground line: the mouth of a cave.

Founding trade: the lines that went down to the caves.

Three kin



A person marries outside the line. The line name and, usually, the Wind-Kin pass down; the house stays in the line.

Amira — personal name

kin-Hanga — Wind-Kin (formal use)

Wekesa — line name

Rules of the kin

A child

takes the line of either parent and the Wind-Kin of one. Idi kin-Moto Kamau may be "born to the Wind and walking with Fire".

A move to the caves

may make a person kin-Kivuli. The line name stays.

No Wind-Kin

is no lack: the person has no sign, and draws water under the line name.

In daily speech

nobody says the Wind-Kin. It is for introductions, ceremonies, records and negotiations between settlements.

The kin leader

of each Wind-Kin in a town mediates between its houses, speaks for it, and takes the general seat of the council in turn.

The trades

of the founding lines are tradition. A clan says nothing about a person's work or gift; only the Shadow clan is still tied to a place.

Where the sign goes

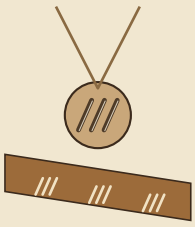
At the tally: the house draws its measures under it

On the doorpost, at the height of a hand

Under the cups of the family

On the name tablets of the dead

On the seal of a contract



Worn: a carved pendant, or stitched into the sash

The signs are drawn as they are carved: a few cuts, in stone, wood or clay.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

Under the Night

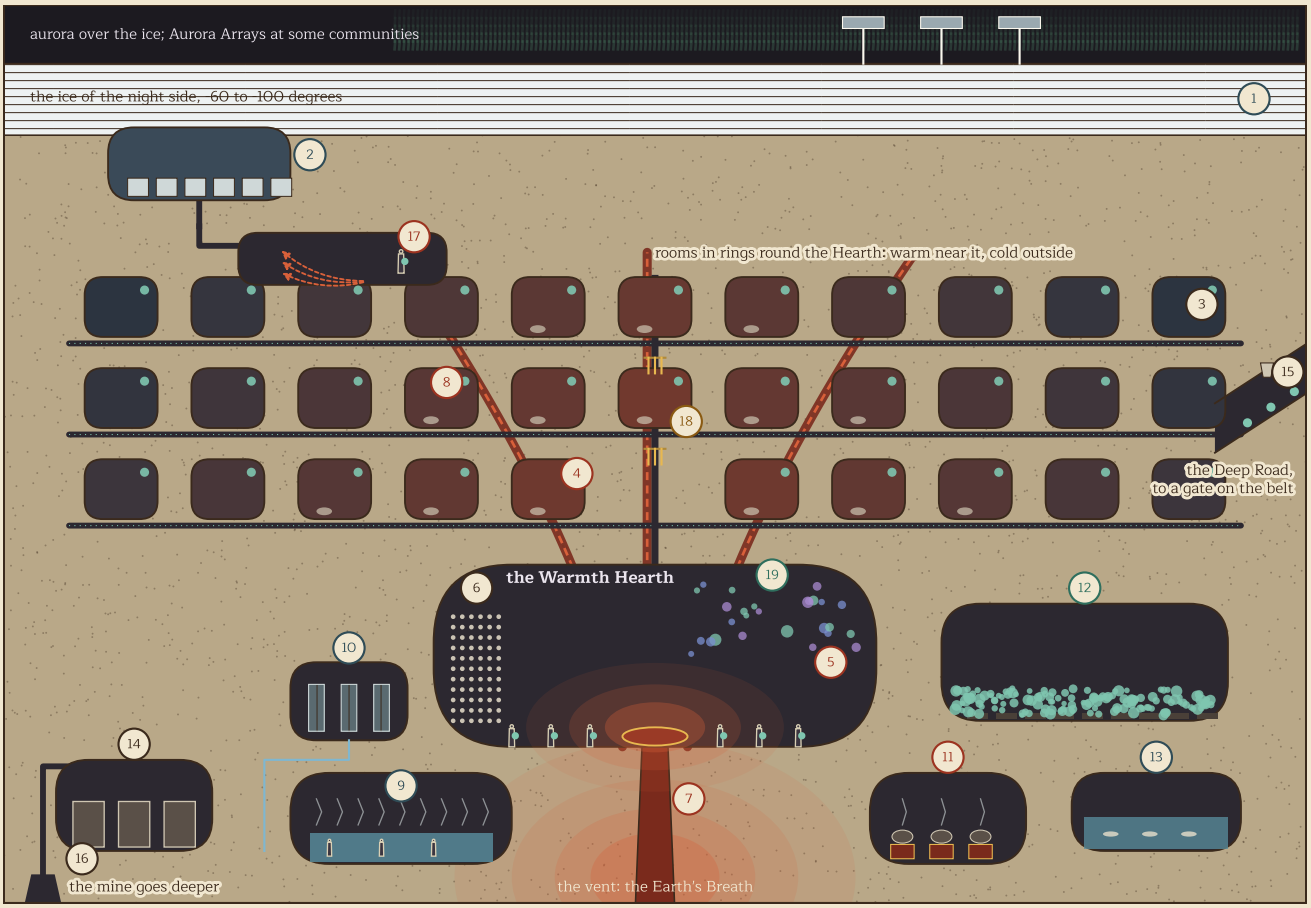
One plate goes under the ice, to the hearth of a Deepkin family, where the warmth comes from the rock and not from the star. Compare it with the common house of the belt to see what the two peoples share and where they differ.

Plate 21 A Deepkin Hearth

Plate 21

A Deepkin Hearth

Daŋa-Hai, the Living Edge · a community of the night side, cut through its Warmth Hearth · a diagram, not to scale



Warmth is the measure of a place

Families change rooms by rota, so that nobody keeps the cold for all time. A Belter who hears this does not know what to say: on the belt a house stays in its line for generations.

Under the night

Light. From living things, from the floor and the walls as often as from above: a face is lit from beneath. Nothing has a fixed shadow.

Air. Warm, damp and still. Hair lies flat. A flame stands straight.

Smell. Mineral water, fungus, a little sulfur; steam from the kitchens; warm stone; many people in one place.

Sound. Every sound goes far and comes back. People speak low and slowly. A person is known by their step. In the outer tunnels the silence is complete.

1 The ice

The night side above the caves: ice sheets and frost, -60 to -100 degrees. Some communities keep Aurora Arrays on it.

2 The cold vault

A natural ice cave that keeps food and materials.

3 The outer caverns

Cold. Nobody keeps them for all time.

4 The inner rooms

Warm, near the Hearth. Families change rooms by rota. People own little, and belong to the Hearth more than to a room.

5 The Warmth Hearth

The heart of the community: decisions, the sharing of resources, the rites. The Warmth Circle meets here.

6 The bone wall

One small piece of burned bone from each of the dead, kept by the Bone Lorekeepers, who say the names.

7 The vent

The Earth's Breath. The dead are burned at a vent. Near it the rock itself is a dim red.

8 The heat channels

Heat moves up from the deep vent through engineered channels, not out from the surface.

9 The hot pools

Water is warm. People sit in the pools and are cleaner than any Belter.

10 The steam condensers

Water comes from steam.

11 The kitchens

Food is steamed or cooked on the vents. There is no smoke.

12 The glow farms

Glowcaps for light, food and medicine, in the warmth that no wind phase changes.

13 The fish pools

Blind fish, and the shellfish of the hot pools.

14 The bio-recyclers

Organic waste into fuel and compost for the cultivation chambers.

15 The Deep Road

To a gate on the belt. A stone bell at its mouth carries signals.

16 The mine

Miners go deeper for ore, crystal and water, and cut the next stretch of the Deep Roads.

17 A cave weatherworker

Moto-kunga moves warm air, not storms: through tunnels and halls, and against the cold of the outer caverns.

18 The chimes

Geothermal chimes ring in the warm air that rises.

19 The living murals

Inks of living fungi and bacteria on prepared stone: deep blue, soft green, purple.

The caves are dark; what is drawn in light is what gives light. Depths, sizes and the number of rooms are not surveyed.
A drawing of the Archivists, Cycle 8,430, translated from the Creole.

License

Duskara Illustrated

© 2026 Roberto Bisceglie

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International License. To view a copy of this license, visit http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/ or send a letter to Creative Commons, PO Box 1866, Mountain View, CA 94042, USA.